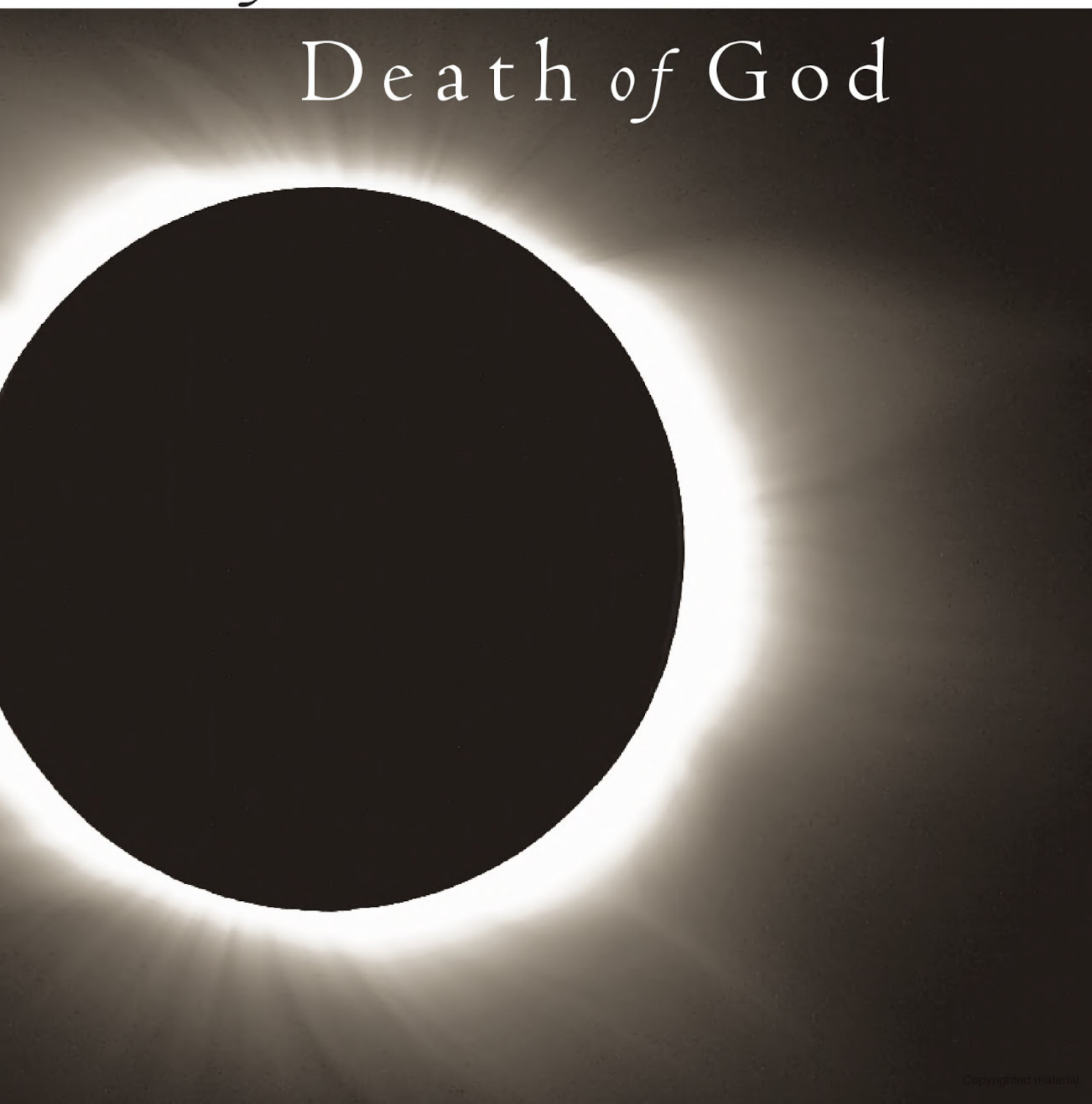


John D. CAPUTO, Gianni VATTIMO

Edited by Jeffrey W. ROBBINS

After the

Death of God



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With an Afterword by Gabriel VAHANIAN

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Introduction

After the Death of God

In religion's perpetual agony lies its philosophical and theoretical relevance. As it dies an ever more secure and serial death, it is increasingly certain to come back to life, in its present guise or in another.

—HENT DE VRIES, *Philosophy and the Turn to Religion*

I

Is God Dead?

So that, in truth, Thou didst Thyself lay the foundation for the destruction of Thy kingdom, and no one is more to blame for it. Yet what was offered Thee? There are three powers, three powers alone, able to conquer and to hold captive for ever the conscience of these impotent rebels for their happiness—those forces are miracle, mystery, and authority. Thou has rejected all three and hast set the example for doing so.

—DOSTOYEVSKY, “The Grand Inquisitor”

On April 8, 1966, the cover of *Time* asked, “Is God Dead?” When published, it was the best-selling issue in the magazine's history. It announced to the public a theological movement that was making its way into the mainstream—namely, radical death of God theology. This theological movement was in fact a collection of various disparate voices and perspectives. It ranged from the cultural theologians' grappling with what they termed

the “post-Christian era,”¹ to the largely Jewish effort at developing a “post-Holocaust theology,”² to the popular reformational efforts of the Anglican bishop John Robinson’s book *Honest to God* and Harvey Cox’s *Secular City*,³ and, finally, to the metaphysical death of God theology of Thomas J. J. Altizer.⁴

What they all shared in common was a collective sense that Western culture in general, and the Judeo-Christian tradition in particular, had entered a profound “ideological crisis.”⁵ Either religious language had lost its meaning or, even worse, the inherited meanings had grown perverse in the wake of a long list of modern atrocities. World wars, genocides, nuclear armament, and the cold war standoff between the East and the West—together these twentieth-century realities turned the optimism associated with the modern period to a deep and lasting pessimism. As the contemporary political philosophers Antonio Negri and Michael Hardt have written:

Modern negativity is located not in any transcendent realm but in the hard reality before us: the fields of patriotic battles in the First and Second World Wars, from the killing fields at Verdun to the Nazi furnaces and the swift annihilation of thousands in Hiroshima and Nagasaki, the carpet bombing of Vietnam and Cambodia, the massacres from Setif and Soweto to Sabra and Shatila, and the list goes on and on. There is no Job who can sustain such suffering!⁶

Those who spoke of the death of God, therefore, were attempting to locate themselves within this “hard reality before us,” and, like the ancient book of Job from the Hebrew Scriptures, they were asking the age-old question of theodicy about the meaning of suffering and the reasons for God’s apparent silence in the midst of it all. They were acknowledging that the old moral and theological platitudes had somehow fallen short and admitting

that the Bible's answer of vicarious suffering is perhaps inadequate in the face of the twentieth century's experience of genocide and potential for nuclear annihilation. To borrow a phrase from the German theologian Dietrich Bonhoeffer, we can consider the death of God movement as a "coming-of-age," an effort at honoring our history by following a certain cultural and theological rite of passage.

In this sense, even though the preoccupation of contemporary theology no longer centers around the death of God, this radical theological movement still speaks to us today as it testifies to a moment of transition and crisis within Western religious consciousness and thereby helps to establish the genealogy that would develop into what we now know as postmodern theology. Indeed, two of the main theorists of postmodern theology, Carl Raschke and Mark C. Taylor, both suggested a direct link between the death of God and postmodern deconstructive philosophies. As Taylor wrote in his landmark work, *Erring*, from 1984, "Deconstruction is the 'hermeneutic' of the death of God."⁷ In addition, the death of God theologies came to be associated with a certain spirit of secularism that permeates almost all facets of contemporary Western society.

Of course, long before theologians explicitly took up this thematic of the death of God in the 1960s, philosophers, historians, novelists, and cultural observers had already made this connection between the collapse of Christendom and the birth of a new, more secular culture. Indeed, the distinction between Christendom and Christianity can be seen as one of the defining features of the Christian faith in the late modern and postmodern world and is certainly integral for establishing the cultural conditions for radical theology.⁸ This distinction between Christendom and Christianity spawns from a well-known historical narrative that refers to the imperial religion of Christianity that began in the fourth century CE when the Emperor Constantine effectively

established Christianity as the religion of the Roman Empire. Constantine's edict of toleration in 312 CE ended nearly three centuries of sporadic, though at times quite severe, state-sanctioned Christian persecution. By the end of the fourth century, however, Christianity had become both the dominant and official religion of the Roman Empire and, with the possible exception of the few hangers-on such as the desert monks and a select group of monastics, the Christian church had fully embraced its newfound alliance with the powers that be. As the church historian Hugh McLeod explains, this alliance established a "pattern of relations between church and state and between church and society" that would prevail for at least the next fifteen hundred years as "most Christians learnt and practiced their faith in the context of 'Christendom.'" McLeod continues: "That is, they lived in a society where there were close ties between the leaders of the church and those in positions of secular power, where the laws purported to be based on Christian principles, and where, apart from certain clearly defined outsider communities, every member of society was assumed to be a Christian."⁹

By wedding the church with the Roman Empire or, more broadly, with Western culture, the Constantinian revolution successfully harnessed the three powers identified by Dostoyevsky by adding the authority of the state to that of the church's already firm grasp on miracle and mystery. In so doing, the power of the church was consolidated in the creation and spread of a distinctively Christian culture. Along the way, however, the witness of Christ—especially his suffering and death—was lost in his exaltation by the now triumphant church. It would seem, therefore, and this is something that Dostoyevsky's Grand Inquisitor knew well: that the glory of the church was built on its rejection of Christ as the persecuted became the persecutors, and the servant the new Lord and master. From death, to resurrection, to exaltation—here we have the death of God in Christ twice over.

(Religion) In the Shadow of Christendom

We are not working with Thee, but with him—that is our mystery. It's long—eight centuries—since we have been on his side and not on Thine. Just eight centuries ago, we took from him what Thou didst reject with scorn, that last gift he offered Thee, showing Thee all the kingdoms of the earth. We took from him Rome and the sword of Caesar, and proclaimed ourselves sole rulers of the earth, though hitherto we have not been able to complete our work. But whose fault is that? Oh, the work is only beginning, but it has begun. It has long to await completion and the earth has yet much to suffer, but we shall triumph and shall be Caesars, and then we shall plan the universal happiness of man.

—DOSTOYEVSKY, “The Grand Inquisitor”

It is a fine line between the servant becoming the master and the exchange of one master for another. Perhaps, as Dostoyevsky suggests, the Christianization of culture was a devil's bargain from the start. Such is the argument of those like Elaine Pagels whose appreciation of the early Gnostic literature points to a time *before* the Christian community came to be defined by a specific set of authorized beliefs. As Pagels tells it and as our increasing knowledge of the Gnostic literature confirms, the first centuries of the church was a time of great diversity in terms of beliefs and practices. It was also a time during which many different Christian communities seemed to flourish, even in the face of official state persecution. But eventually this diversity came to be seen more as a threat than as a sign of the vitality of the church. In order to prevent what was called the “wild readings” of the gospel and “evil exegesis” of the scriptural tradition, a line was drawn identifying what was formerly thought of as heterodoxy now as heresy. “But,” as Pagels writes, “it would take more than theological argument for [this] viewpoint to prevail. . . . It

would take, in fact, the revolution initiated by the Roman emperor Constantine.”¹⁰ A devil’s bargain that gave the leaders of the church the needed authority not only to define orthodoxy but also to enforce their vision of the church’s proper uniformity and homogeneity. Through this newly established framework of canon, creed, and ecclesiastical authority, the world could now be made in the image of the church, the kingdom of God would now (finally) come.

Or if not a devil’s bargain then perhaps a fool’s dream. To be fair, this dream or ideal of Christendom—namely, that society would be made in the image of the church and that the Christian faith would permeate all aspects of social, cultural, religious, and even political life—was never fully realized. This is the case not simply because of the external challenge that was posed by non-Christians (whether they were in the image of pagans, Jews, Muslims, or primitives) but also because of the internal debate that existed amongst Christians themselves about the proper relation between church and society and the proper understanding of the Christian identity. As McLeod writes:

At most points of Christian history there have been those who have opposed the identity between church and society or over-close links between church and state, or between the church and social elites. From the fourth century onwards there have been Christians who saw these associations as damaging to the church: “Christendom” meant that the church was subject to state interference, that it was forced to admit into membership those who were not true Christians, and that it was under pressure to condone contemporary customs and values that were unchristian.¹¹

While this characteristic tension between the faith of Christianity and the culture of Christendom has been central to the

history of Christianity in the West, ever since the Protestant Reformation of the sixteenth century there has been a steady dismantling of the old Constantinian alliance, leading to the eventual collapse of Christendom in the modern era. This collapse of Christendom (which is credited for a whole spectrum of aspects from our contemporary culture ranging from the principle of religious liberty and toleration to the extreme religious skepticism, cynicism, or even nihilism of the modern mind) becomes final or absolute in the first half of the twentieth century as supposedly civilized, and nominally Christian, nations turn against one another in total warfare. In other words, the ideal of Western civilization held together by a common Christian heritage and identity gets turned against itself in its full destructive potential. In the process, Christendom is revealed as “no more than a phase in the history of Christianity, and it represents only one out of many possible relationships between church and society. Yet in Western Europe this phase lasted for more than a thousand years, and we are still living in its shadow.”¹²

Not only Christian theology, but the very practice and piety of contemporary religiosity have been greatly determined by the shadow cast by this collapse of Christendom. It is why twentieth-century Christian observers such Dietrich Bonhoeffer, in his *Letters and Papers from Prison*, began speaking of a “religionless Christianity.”¹³ Bonhoeffer posed this possibility of a religionless Christianity while living out the final days of his life in a prison cell, before his martyrdom for his involvement in an assassination plot against Hitler. As such, his words had an added moral credibility, especially by those like the death of God theologians who were troubled by the moral ineptitude, if not outright complicity, of the church. For Bonhoeffer, this effort at purging Christianity of the comforts of religion would be a risky faith without assurances, one that severs the ties between Christ’s call to discipleship and Christianity’s association with the offices of

power and the religious identification with the cultural trappings of civilization. Bonhoeffer's words and observations came to the world as a prophetic voice from the grave and became the link between, on the one hand, a world-weary faith in shock and horror at its own moral failure and impotence and, on the other, an emergent religious and cultural sensibility that was now forced to pick up the broken pieces and to imagine, if not craft, an alternative future—a future in the wake of the death of God and after the collapse of Christendom. For many, therefore, Bonhoeffer was seen as a precursor to the death of God theologians.¹⁴

Another important precursor was the nineteenth-century existentialist Christian philosopher Søren Kierkegaard. Kierkegaard has always been known as a great literary stylist. His use of pseudonyms, irony, and satire had long since been a source of confusion and frustration for modern rationalists. His religious writings, on the other hand, were another matter. Unlike many Enlightenment and post-Enlightenment thinkers, Kierkegaard seemed to be genuinely appreciative of the religious sentiment. At the same time, few have written such a scathing critique of Christendom and the modern-day church as Kierkegaard accomplished in his *Attack Upon Christendom*.¹⁵ Kierkegaard, like Bonhoeffer and the death of God theologians who followed, gave voice to the new anti-institutional, individualized Christian faith that stood in opposition to the easy alliance between religion and society. It was a radical faith purged of any vestige of authoritarianism and triumphalism that was unafraid to call into question the very meaning and purpose of the church both by being willing to admit the failures of its own tradition and by seeing the great success of the state churches as their great failure. In other words, for Kierkegaard, the apparent Christianization of culture and politics made it virtually impossible to live up to the radical existential demands of a truly biblical faith.

While Bonhoeffer and Kierkegaard were both religious thinkers who each in his own way tried to restore the integrity of the Christian faith, there were other nonreligious, or perhaps even antireligious, thinkers who also informed the eventual shape of the radical death of God movement. It is no surprise, after all, that the death of God movement is celebrated as the embrace and culmination of the modern trend toward a fully secularized culture—or if not fully secularized, at least a culture that had become increasingly suspicious of the institution of religion. That is because, in addition to the theological critiques of Bonhoeffer and Kierkegaard, there were also those such as Marx, Nietzsche, and Freud who were known generally for their “hermeneutics of suspicion” and more specifically for their critique, if not hostility to, religion. In the midst of this cultural milieu the death of God movement lends a sympathetic voice. It speaks of a world in which God, through the act of kenosis, has fully emptied Godself. It admits that the idea of God is often no more than a human projection. It calls for human responsibility and accountability. It points to the fact that religion has just as often been the problem as it has been the solution to human conflict throughout the ages. This radical death of God theology, therefore, represents a critical and prophetic voice in the midst of a culture and faith in crisis, one that was moving away from the old religious certainties and assurances and toward a transformed religious sensibility. Further still, it is perhaps the quintessential representative theology for a Christian faith waking up to its new cultural reality in the shadow of Christendom. The irony is that by embracing a culture that was increasingly hostile toward religion, the death of God theology not only helps to lay the groundwork for postmodernism by its early critique of the moral-metaphysical God of ontotheology but also sets the conditions for a recovery of a distinctly biblical faith that gives emphasis not to the power and glory of God but

to God's suffering and love—from the being of God to the story of God's being with the poor, the hungry, and the outcast.

The Postmodern Return of Religion

When the Inquisitor ceased speaking he waited some time for his Prisoner to answer him. His silence weighted down upon him. He saw the Prisoner had listened intently all the time, looking gently in his face and evidently not wishing to reply. The old man longed for Him to say something, however bitter and terrible. But He suddenly approached the old man in silence and softly kissed him on his bloodless ageless lips. That was all His answer. The old man shuddered. His lips moved. He went to the door, opened it, and said to Him: 'Go, and come no more. . . . Come not at all, never, never!' And he let Him out in to the dark alleys of the town. The Prisoner went away.

—DOSTOYEVSKY, "The Grand Inquisitor"

On the one hand, there is the almost two millennia of the power, authority, and triumph of the church. On the other, there is the almost silent witness of Christ. The former bears the heavy weight of history; the latter, the weight of the cross. The genius of Dostoyevsky's Grand Inquisitor is that we can sympathize with his plight and the plight of his church. It is true, as the Grand Inquisitor so mournfully describes, that we human beings are weak and needy. We long for a God who will deliver us to the promised land, not a God who dies and thereby unveils the structure of violence and injustice that reins supreme in this fallen world. We want someone who will save us from ourselves because, try as we might, we continue to botch our freedom. We continue to fight, kill, and hate—sometimes even in the name of God. Perhaps the Grand Inquisitor was right—we human be-

ings cannot be trusted. We must be directed and ruled. We must be fed and clothed. And if not by the church, then by whom? And even if the church has lost its way, who among us is really willing to follow the way of the cross? Therefore, when the Grand Inquisitor speaks, we hear his sadness, pathos, and even resignation. *Ecce homo*—"behold the man"—the one who betrays his true love, the one who suffers for our sakes so that in our weakness we might be saved, the one who knows the truth while the rest of us live by our illusions. Behold the man—the one who suffers the kiss of Christ and who must send Christ on his way and banish him from ever returning again. This is the sad truth and tragedy of religion as revealed by him.

Of course, the prisoner has heard these charges before. He mounts no defense. His only response is that of a kiss and thereby he embodies the essence of his teaching—to love, even one's enemies, even those who condemn him to death. This is a story beyond belief. Who could dare fathom, let alone follow? The strange and unexpected thing is how that kiss, illustrative of the love of Christ, lives on even after the death of the moral-metaphysical God. The irony of Dostoyevsky's story is that though the Grand Inquisitor intends it as an indictment against Christ, it lays bare his desperate desire for him all the same. A similar ironic reversal can be seen in our own modern history. For when examining the current state of theology, philosophy of religion, and contemporary religious thought and practice, the future as charted by the champions of secularism, death of God theologians, and deconstructive philosophers has given way to a new "postsecular" understanding of the postmodern condition in which the return of religion is more determinative than the collapse of Christendom. Indeed, in both philosophical and popular cultural circles, God now seems alive and well, and as the *New York Times* proclaimed in a feature Sunday magazine article from 1998, "religion is making a comeback."¹⁶ In the process,

perhaps the most fundamental assumption of the modern mind has been brought into critical relief—namely, the identification of modernization with secularism.

It had long been assumed by sociologists, philosophers, and theologians alike that the more modern we became, the less religious we would become. Our increased technological proficiency and scientific knowledge were thought to translate into a decreased dependency on outdated religious beliefs in God and supernaturalism. Indeed, the most prominent Enlightenment philosopher of them all, Immanuel Kant, defined the very project of Enlightenment by this most fundamental of all modern assumptions when he wrote that Enlightenment is the release from all forms self-incurred tutelage. What he had in mind, in addition to various forms of political authoritarianism, was the religious authoritarianism and dogmatism that for centuries had discouraged critical scientific inquiry. According to Kant, the enlightened subject would be one who could think for himself, and one in whom religion might still play a part, but only in the private sphere of personal morality.¹⁷ This modern philosophical anticipation of an autonomous subject not constrained by determinative religious beliefs has come under increased scrutiny as contemporary theorists from various disciplines have seemingly reversed the course of modern subjectivity by demonstrating how personal and social identity is a product of social construction, how knowledge is intertwined with power, and how the presumably private and interior life of religion is always already public and political.

What we see, therefore, is a strangely disjointed history. These modern, secularist assumptions, which are now being questioned and brought into doubt more and more, certainly pervade much if not all the radical death of God theologies of the 1960s. The question, which will become the central question that this volume seeks to address, is the following: *How do we get*

from the post-Christian, post-Holocaust, and largely secular death of God theologies of the 1960s to the postmodern return of religion? Put otherwise, what happens when we move from the early claim that deconstruction is the hermeneutic of the death of God to the subsequent effort at deconstructing the death of God? What happens when the critical linking of the death of God with deconstruction comes full circle? And finally, how is it that this question of the return of religion is transmitted not by theologians and/or religious leaders but by and through philosophers and cultural theorists who heretofore had little or no expressed interest in religious or theological questions?

II

This transition from the death of God to postmodern faith (or, if you will, from secularism to postsecularism) is one of the defining chapters in contemporary religious thought. John Caputo and Gianni Vattimo, each in their turn, stand as representative voices of these distinct, though profoundly interrelated, modes of thinking through, and thinking about, the relation of religion to society and the continued viability of theological thinking. The dialogue between them should tell us a great deal not simply about the similarities and differences between two thinkers, the one from the United States and the other from Italy, and two religious perspectives, but even more about the broader currents of our contemporary culture, about how we have moved from religious skepticism (if not outright antagonism toward religion), which is reflective of modernity, to an apparent re-embrace of religion in the postmodern world. Also, what sort of changes, alterations, distortions, or reforms were introduced into this postmodern faith as a result of its passing through the crucible of the death of God critiques? To Vattimo, Caputo will

submit his death of God philosophy to a deconstructive critique. To Caputo, Vattimo will offer his interpretation of the death of God and the modern processes of secularization as a faithful recovery of kenotic Christianity and a reorientation toward the very essence of the Christian faith—namely, that of *agape*.

While each may speak of the philosophical and theological significance of the death of God differently, there are at least three major overlapping areas of interest between Caputo and Vattimo. First and foremost, both Caputo and Vattimo have long been engaged in the effort to radicalize hermeneutic philosophy. For Caputo, this has meant forging a closer collaboration between hermeneutics and deconstruction as both signal a departure from, and work to overcome, the metaphysics of presence.¹⁸ While this linking of hermeneutics with Derridean deconstruction might lead to a certain unknowing, or an epistemological undecidability, for Caputo this should not be understood as an exercise in nihilism.

It is this latter point where Vattimo parts company with Caputo. Like Caputo, he has expressed great appreciation and admiration for Derrida and deconstruction, but, unlike Caputo, Vattimo has argued for the positive contribution that nihilism plays both for an understanding of contemporary hermeneutic philosophy and in the process of emancipation. The contribution nihilism makes is not in the sense that it functions as a new philosophical doctrine or a new truth as it were. On the contrary, nihilism is the name for the series of negations that contemporary thought has undergone from the strong metaphysical assumptions associated with ancient philosophy and carried forward through the Enlightenment rationalistic period to the weak, anti-authoritarian strand of the interpretative philosophy of hermeneutics. As written by his friend and frequent collaborator Richard Rorty, and as demonstrated by his recent book of essays in political philosophy, Vattimo has shown that “nihil-

ism and emancipation do, in fact, go hand in hand.”¹⁹ In Vattimo’s own words, “Nihilism acquires the sense of emancipation” when we realize that “it is the dissolution of foundations . . . that brings freedom.”²⁰ That is because, as Vattimo writes, “a weak ontology, or better an ontology of the weakening of Being, supplies philosophical reasons for preferring a liberal, tolerant, and democratic society rather than an authoritarian and totalitarian one.”²¹ In addition, Vattimo also sees nihilism as synonymous with hermeneutics as both acknowledge that any argument is always historically and culturally situated and as both recognize the necessity for dialogue. In this way Vattimo identifies hermeneutics as “the thought of accomplished nihilism, thought that aims to reconstruct rationality in the wake of the death of God and opposes any current of negative nihilism, in other words the desperation of those who continue to cultivate a sense of mourning because ‘religion is no more.’”²²

This leads to the second overlapping area of interest between Caputo and Vattimo—namely, that of weak thought.²³ Both Caputo and Vattimo have spoken about, and examined the consequences of, the weakening of thought. For Caputo, this interest in weak thought has accompanied his increased attention to the religious question in recent years, which was first signaled by his enormously successful and influential study of the religious dimension to the deconstructive philosophy of Derrida.²⁴ Since that first sustained philosophical turn to religion, Caputo has published a great deal about religion and postmodernism, and, largely due to the great success he has had in organizing the bi-annual conferences on this subject, first at Villanova and now at Syracuse University, he has helped to spearhead and define the burgeoning field of continental philosophy of religion. But when Caputo speaks about the postmodern return of religion, he almost invariably invokes the qualifier he learned from Derrida—namely, “religion without religion.” In contrast to the variant of

contemporary religiosity that asserts itself strongly and triumphantly, Caputo offers a postcritical religion in the sense that he wants to affirm faith, though without absolute or certain knowledge, and he seeks to value religious tradition, while keeping his distance from the actual historic faith communities. In short, his is not a theology of power but a theology of weakness that connects the weakness of God with the ethical imperative to serve the poor and needy. In contrast to the historical determinacy and specificity of the strong Christian, Jewish, or Islamic theologies, Caputo offers a more open-ended theology “weakened by the flux of undecidability and translatability.” According to Caputo’s description, it is a “theology of the event,” which we can think of ironically as a “theology without theology.”²⁵

The origin of Vattimo’s interest in weak thought precedes his own philosophical turn to religion. Indeed, the very phrase *weak thought* is perhaps Vattimo’s primary contribution to contemporary philosophy and the means by which he has informed and shaped the contemporary reading of the legacy of Nietzsche, Heidegger, and postmodernism. The phrase *weak thought* refers to the gradual weakening of being that has transformed contemporary philosophy from its former obsession with the metaphysics of truth to its current and more limited understanding of itself strictly as an interpretative exercise. The irony is that this weak ontology also weakens the strong metaphysical reasons for atheism and the rationalist repudiation of religion. So not only does weak thought precede the philosophical turn to religion but, according to the narrative offered by Vattimo, it actually establishes the philosophical precondition for the postmodern return of the religious. Vattimo argues that in the postmetaphysical age not only is the world desacralized, and not only does faith lose its assurances, but along with this secularization of religion—which he sees as the truth of the gospel and the destiny of the West—there also occurs the breakdown or dissolution of

the tyranny of reason from which the modern critique, dismissal, or reduction of religion derived. In other words, as Vattimo puts it, “The end of metaphysics and the death of the moral God have liquidated the philosophical basis of atheism.”²⁶ In this sense atheism is nothing but the flip side of theism, with neither understanding the true nature of belief, because both according to Vattimo’s analysis still rely on absolutist claims characteristic of scientific positivism or transcendent authority.²⁷ Now that we live in the postmetaphysical age in which there are no absolute truths, only interpretations, the category of belief can again be taken seriously as constitutive of our lived traditions.

Third, Caputo and Vattimo are two of the world’s chief theorists of postmodernism in general—and the possibility of postmodern religion more specifically. Regarding a general theory or praxis of postmodernism, Caputo’s radical hermeneutics can be seen as an effort to update hermeneutic philosophy for what has become a vastly different cultural milieu from its origins with its altered modes of intelligibility associated with the postmodern condition. In this sense to radicalize hermeneutics is to show its continued relevancy in the postmodern world. Similarly, with his effort at “demythologizing Heidegger,” Caputo shows the same knack for rejuvenation by acknowledging the greatness of Heidegger and at the same time critically examining the source for his personal flaws and political blindness. In doing so, Caputo demonstrates how postmodern deconstruction is not strictly a negative philosophy but instead an attempt to read the tradition against itself—indeed, even to read a single thinker against himself. In this way postmodern deconstruction is necessarily a twofold operation. As Caputo describes it with respect to his deconstructive reading of Heidegger:

It is not only a negative work of exposing the insinuations of the myth of Being into the question of Being, of mercilessly

“*also* perspectives, *also* constructions, or fictions of grammar.” In Caputo’s words:

Marx and Freud, along with Nietzsche himself, find themselves hoisted with Nietzsche’s petard, their critiques of religion having come undone under the gun of Nietzsche’s critique of the possibility of making a critique that would cut to the quick—of God, nature, or history. Enlightenment secularism, the objectivist reduction of religion to something other than itself—say, to a distorted desire for one’s mommy, or to a way to keep the ruling authorities in power—is one more story told by people with historically limited imaginations, with contingent conceptions of reason and history, of economics and labor, of nature and human nature, of desire, sexuality, and women, and of God, religion, and faith. (59–60)

In short, Caputo sees postmodernity as “a more enlightened Enlightenment [that] is no longer taken in by the dream of Pure Objectivity. . . . It has a post-critical sense of critique that is critical of the idea that we can establish air-tight borders around neatly discriminated spheres or regions like knowledge, ethics, art, and religion” (61). And, finally, this “opens the doors to another way of thinking about faith and reason,” which for Caputo translates not into relativism, irrationalism, or nihilism “but [into] a heightened sense of the contingency and revisability of our constructions, not the jettisoning of reason but a redescription of reason, one that is a lot more reasonable than the bill of goods about an overarching, transhistorical Rationality that the Enlightenment tried to sell us” (63).

Thus from modernity to postmodernity, from secularization to a process of desecularization through which religion has moved from being on the defensive for having to answer to reason to its

contemporary rebound where it has recovered its proper sense as a faith rather than some lesser form of knowledge. As Caputo writes in his conclusion to *On Religion*, “Religious truth is a truth without Knowledge” (115). And further, “Undecidability is the place in which faith takes place, the night in which faith is conceived, for night is its element. Undecidability is the reason that faith is faith and not Knowledge, and the way that faith can be true without Knowledge” (128).

Vattimo, on the other hand, has an alternative reading of postmodernism that rests on a very different, more positive, understanding of the modern processes of secularization. As he states in the interview that follows, “Real religiosity relies on secularization.” By this he is referring to the modern fragmentation of religious authority that has both positive and negative consequences. Positively, it safeguards religious belief from coercion and at least provides the possibility that believers might recognize the contingency and historicity of their own beliefs. But, on the flip side, a religion severed from institutional control means that like most everything else in contemporary society it becomes just another commodity in the world of mass communication. For Vattimo, this is at least part of the explanation for the wild popularity of Pope John Paul II. As he says, “People are more interested in the religious show than they are in religious engagement.” And later in the conversation, as if to underscore the point of the pope’s status as a media star, “Many people watch TV, but not so many attend church.”

With this in mind, to what extent does he share Caputo’s linking of the postmodern with the postsecular? And if we are living in a postsecular world, does this mean that the postmodern has inaugurated a process of desecularization? With regard to the first question, Vattimo answers in the affirmative in the sense that in the contemporary postmodern society, we are witness to a certain rebirth of religiosity. The postmodern is postsecular in

perfect knowledge of the necessary structure of reality and conforming to it,” but instead is conceived as disorientation by virtue of the dissolution of reality. As Vattimo writes, “If, in the multicultural world, I set out my system of religious, aesthetic, political and ethnic values, I shall be acutely conscious of the historicity, contingency and finiteness of these systems, starting with my own” (9).

This more positive reading of the history of secularization and more hopeful, if not optimistic, reading of the postmodern as the postmetaphysical leads to Vattimo taking distance from what he calls the “tragic and apocalyptic Christianity of Dostoevsky”³³ with whom we began and about whom Caputo will conclude our dialogue. Although Dostoevsky’s tale of the Grand Inquisitor certainly employs the tragic in this most existential spiritual crisis, it also anticipates a history—namely, our history of the postmodern return of a religion based in the love of Christ. On that, both Caputo and Vattimo can agree.

In the pages of this book that follow, our quest for a new philosophy of religion will pass through the radical hermeneutics of John Caputo and Gianni Vattimo, through the movement of the death of God to the postmodern realization of the death of the death of God, from secularism to the return of religion, and beyond. In the process, and by virtue of the open form of the dialogues that follow, both Caputo and Vattimo will be given the chance to think “otherwise” by thinking in conversation with one another. To return to the epigraph from Hent de Vries: what follows represents the perpetual agony of a conversation without end as we explore the contours of the seeming impossible—a theology after the death of God and a philosophy of religion without religion.

I

in its eventual focus on the ethical-political nature of metaphysics, the “rationalization” of modern society against which the vanguards during the first part of the twentieth century were fighting. Heidegger also realized that the scientific claim of objectivity (which is also what Lukacs says under a Marxist’s profile) is inspired from a determined interest: for example, to describe a natural phenomenon in a way that others could also speak of it in the same way and develop this self-same knowledge. In other words, scientists are not moved by the impulse of truth. The relation between the world and the knowledge of the world does not function as a mirror. Instead, there is the world and someone who is “in the world,” which means someone who orients himself in and to the world, someone who uses his own capacities of knowledge, hence someone who chooses, reorganizes, replaces, represents, etc.

The concept of interpretation is all here: there is no experience of truth that is not interpretative. I do not know anything that does not interest me. If it does interest me, it is evident that I do not look at it in a noninterested way.

For Heidegger, this concept of interpretation also makes its way into his reflection on the historical sciences, as one can see reading not only the first parts of *Being and Time* but also so many other essays of that period. For Heidegger, then, it comes down to the following: I am an interpreter as long as I am not someone who looks at the world from the outside. I see the external world because I am inside it. As a being-in-the-world, my interests are very complicated. I cannot say precisely how things are, but only how they are from this point of view, how they seem to me and how I think they are. If an experiment moved by one of my ideas works, it does not mean that I have exhausted the objective knowledge on that aspect of reality. Rather, as even the philosophy of science has later realized, I have made the experiment function under certain expectations and premises. When

I conduct an experiment, after all, I already have a whole set of criteria and instruments thanks to which I may determine—always with another someone who comes to the experiment with other interests and thus, by definition, does not think exactly as I do—whether my experiment works or not. From the beginning, the criteria and the instruments are left out of the discussion. No scientist studies all physics from scratch. Nearly all of them trust handbooks, and, with the help of the inherited knowledge contained therein, they develop still others.

This point made by Heidegger almost a century ago is an accepted fact by now—scientists do not objectively describe the world. On the contrary, their description of the world depends on their specific usage of precise instruments and a rigorous methodology, all of which is culturally determined and historically qualified. Of course, I realize that not all scientists would accept these words. But even the very conditions of possibility for verifying a scientific proposition (or falsifying, as Popper would have it) depend on the fact that we speak the same language, we use the same instruments, we take the same measures, etc. If any of this were different, not only would we not understand each other, but we would not even have the possibility of understanding each other. And, further, these criteria and this paradigm have not been invented from scratch. On the contrary, we have inherited them.

Again, this is interpretation: being inside a situation, facing it not as someone who comes from Mars but as someone who has a history, as someone who belongs to a community.

There are some people who believe that to study physics is not to study the truth of physics, but to learn the secret skills and practices and to endure the various rites of initiation, like an athlete getting in shape or an initiate becoming a member of a secret society. It makes sense when one considers the difficulty in getting someone to understand a scientific demonstration. In

Returning to the crucible of cultural anthropology, and with the increased appreciation for the finitude of existence, perhaps now even mathematics is revealed as only *a* mathematics. This is seen in the beginning of the twentieth century with the development of alternative mathematics, non-Euclidean geometries. I must confess that I do not know why people invent these things, but it is always about systems, about logical mathematical connections that really do work and through which it is possible to demonstrate certain truths. When it is discovered that perhaps they can be applied more adequately to some natural phenomenon than others—for instance, some suggest that certain non-Euclidean geometries apply better to cosmic space—one begins to understand that there might be different languages that deal with phenomena in different ways.

Wittgenstein, who was not a great friend of Heidegger (in fact, I do not think that Heidegger ever read him), says, for example, that if someone puts forward a mathematical formula that gives different results from mine, I may always ask myself if he is getting the calculus wrong or if he is applying a different mathematical language. This is already a way to understand the idea of interpretation. That does not imply that if we accept the idea of interpretation, then “everything goes” and anyone can say whatever he wants. Regardless, there are rules, but the rules themselves are relative to language. This is the importance of the later Wittgenstein’s insight into language games, wherein every language functions like a game with its own rules. Obviously, you cannot apply to a game of basketball the rules of baseball. Otherwise, the norms of basketball would be violated. This does not mean the baseball rules are wrong, but it means that each language has its own norms.

So Christianity contributes to a philosophy of interpretation for many reasons.³ One of these is that Christianity turns the mind inward and thus, say the historians of thought, makes possible the

The history of the origin of the idea of interpretation is inescapable.⁴ Consider the New Testament gospels, none of which were written before 60 ce. In other words, as is well chronicled, the stories of Jesus as the Christ were written sufficiently *after* the time of Jesus such that it is reasonable to conclude that none are eyewitness accounts and that none preserve for us a journalistic record of the actual happenings. One of the reasons why Heidegger chose to comment on Saint Paul's Letters to the Thessalonians, in his "The Phenomenology of Religious Life" course of 1919–1920,⁵ is because they are the oldest writings from the New Testament and thus represent the earliest layer of Christian history we can now access. All of which is to say that even when we are referring to the canonical gospels—those texts that the church has long since established as authoritative and trustworthy—they are at best written reports based on an oral tradition.

I recognize that these are all scattered observations and premises drawn from the history of interpretation and its battle against objectivity. But what is its significance? The answer is that Christianity is a stimulus, a message that sets in motion a tradition of thought that will eventually realize its freedom from metaphysics. Does this mean that metaphysics should have never existed, that Aristotle was somehow wrong or misguided? No, because to say that would be to fall into the trap of metaphysics. It would be an example of typical metaphysical reasoning—namely, affirming that it is an eternal truth that metaphysics is a mistake. I cannot and would not say this, but, in order to say something, or anything, I must draw on particular words, and, in order for those words to make sense, they must be drawn from some particular tradition. If you were to ask me why I feel so confident as to preach this message of freedom from metaphysics without falling into the trap of metaphysics, I would offer you a litany: "Did you read this or that?" In other words, the only arguments

I can offer are not those that are traditionally recognized as such by those who police the rules of logic. My argument is not traditional, but one of transmission, of language, and of the culture in which we live together.

For instance, when I say that I am certain that God created me, I recognize that if I were to strip myself of the biblical world of meaning and reference, I would strip myself of meaning altogether. So to take away the Bible is to take away meaning. It would be like taking Dante away from the history of Italian literature. Dante, like Shakespeare, is written in such a way that, if you did not read the Bible, you would not understand anything. But you can read the Bible without reading Dante or Shakespeare. This means that to profess faith in Christianity is first of all to profess faith in the inevitability of a certain textual tradition that has been passed down to me. Take away the Bible and I would not be what I am. Perhaps I would be something or someone else, but it would be useless for me to think that I could just as easily be a native of the Amazon. It is true that I could be, but how does that help me to understand who I *actually* am? If I reflect on my existence, I must realize that without the text of the Bible I would be bereft of the very instruments I have in order to think and to talk.

The twentieth-century Italian philosopher and political figure Benedetto Croce once said, "We cannot but call ourselves Christians."⁶ I have referred to this statement many times, pulling it in different directions, even taking it to an extreme position that Croce probably would not share. For instance, when he says that "we cannot but call ourselves Christians," I say more extremely that we cannot even speak but from a Christian point of view. That is because we are fundamentally incapable of formulating ourselves, fundamentally incapable of articulating a discourse, except by accepting certain culturally conditioned premises.

Think here of Voltaire: For many, Voltaire is considered an enemy of religion. But I say that Voltaire was a good Christian

precisely because he demanded freedom against authoritarianism, even if it just so happened that it was the Jesuits who were in authority at that particular time and place. By standing unconditionally for freedom and against authoritarianism, he stood for Christianity. In this way perhaps true Christianity must be non-religious. In Christianity there is a fundamental commitment to freedom. And, to add a bit of scandal, by standing for freedom, this includes freedom from (the idea of) truth. After all, if there really is an objective truth, there will always be someone who is more in possession of it than I and thereby authorized to impose its law obligation on me.

Look around, all forms of authoritarianism are founded on some premises of a metaphysical nature, if for no other reason but the fact that authority is easier to explain and apparently more binding if it is construed metaphysically rather than a government or philosophical official trying to persuade you that a certain action, policy, or belief is in your own best interest. If you were to go and explain to President Bush, for instance, that the risks of the war in Iraq are too monumental, he will respond: "But they are terrorists." I can try to understand the sentiment that they might be terrorists, but only within a logic that Bush himself established. Even the document 1441 of the United Nations, which authorized military action in Iraq, is of the United Nations as determined by the Security Council. In other words, it reflects the will of the winners of the World War II. It is not the voice of God! So even though it is the only form of global legitimacy that we have in place, its importance must not be exaggerated to the point of being sacralized. Recognizing this helps us to recognize the illegitimacy of a preemptive war.

To offer a different example: If Christianity did not liberate us from objective truth, how could we even maintain our belief in Scripture, or how could we prevent Scripture from being logically inconsistent, if not utterly absurd? For instance, I

have a colleague in Turin who has written a book in which he actually calculated the height Mary would have reached when she was taken to heaven with her body. The problem, of course, with such calculations is that they generate more questions than they answer. For instance, where is Mary's body now? How do we know that she didn't just disappear? She was taken with the body, but where did she end up? Why are such calculations and questions even necessary in the first place? How can Scripture be saved from such absurdities? In short, to believe in the gospel in today's day and age, one must first understand that language does not only denote objective realities. There is also another language that says other things. Just as it is when I affirm a scientific proposition: I accept the fact that its truth rests on a certain conception of knowledge, a certain accepted code of experimentation, and the use of certain instruments. In this way, I may accept the truth of science without being a scientist myself—that is, I do not have to personally recreate the conditions of an experiment to accept its findings. If not, I would be caught in an infinite regress. It is no different when we come to the discourse of values. I cannot speak outside a certain linguistic tradition without drawing on a certain encyclopedia of knowledge and a dictionary of terms. These are all the basis of my existence.

Likewise, with the language of the gospel, I can only understand it as that which is not ontic, not given in the external world, nor is it meant to be interpreted realistically. Instead, it talks of my destiny. When you say "I love you" on Valentine's Day, this "I love you" does not describe any objective phenomenon. Perhaps you might point to the rapid beating of your pulse as objective evidence of your feeling of love, but so too might it be evidence of something else. Once again we find ourselves in this discourse of interpretation. Until Galileo it was not so easy to be Kantian in science. Only with modern science, with Bacon, but most of all from Galileo onward, has this world been seen

and understood from a scientific perspective in such a way that it seems perfectly suited for the philosophy of Kant. Also this seems to be confirmation of what Dilthey said of Christianity, as the Christian message eventually realizes its destiny when we become aware of our action in the world.

Charity and the Future of Christianity

Where will it all end? And where are we going to end up? We are moving toward secularization, which may also be called nihilism. Hence, the idea is that objective being has gradually, little by little, consumed itself.

In a beautiful passage from *The Twilight of the Idols*, Nietzsche tells us how the real world has become a dream. It was the Platonic world of ideas that gave us the idea of the real world in the first place. Later, the real world was construed as the promised world after death (at least for the righteous). Still later, in the mind of Descartes, the thought of the real world was evidence of clear and distinct ideas (but only in my mind). With positivism the real world became the world of experimental verified truths and then a product of the experimental scientist (after all, the modern scientist is not someone so much who looks at nature as someone who stimulates it, teases it, pulls it, and wants some specific thing to come from it). At this point, the so-called real world has become a story that we tell each other. It is difficult to accept all this, but we live today in a story-world of this kind.

Living in this story-world of our creation, we do not see nature anymore. Instead, we mostly see our world, a world that has been increasingly organized through a whole series of technological entities. When we talk about our natural needs, we list such things as the elevator or the cinema—things that are in no real sense natural but have become perfectly natural and apparently

indispensable for us. What would become of us if we had to survive in a world in which we were left entirely alone? Our natural needs are defined by whatever it is in which we are immersed. But they are not natural at all. They are, instead, stimulated by advertising, conditioned by technology, etc. Our world has become a dream in so many ways. You see a car accident and you run home to see it on television. What is seen on television is then thought to have some heightened sense of reality. It is through television that you are able to see the accident in its full reality instead of the limited vantage point by which you saw it from the road. We live this televised reality locally and globally day after day.

That the real world becomes a dream can also be expressed in terms of Nietzsche's nihilism. As the objective world consumes itself, it gives way to a growing subjective transformation not of individuals but of communities, cultures, sciences, and languages. This is what I theorized with the notion of weak thought. If there is a possible line of emancipation in our human history, emancipation comes not through the final realization of an essence that was given at the beginning once and for all (which therefore would mean that we must somehow return to our state of original innocence before original sin). We must realize a bigger transformation as the natural gives way to the cultural or the material to the spiritual. This is what Hegel meant when he spoke about making the world into the house of man. It is not unlike the effort of making one's house into a home. When decorating a house, it is not just a matter of providing comfortable furniture or a welcoming environment. Once everything is arranged, if something is then missing or out of place you cannot help but notice its absence immediately. What makes your house a home is the artificial order you establish.

Baudelaire wrote a wonderful thing: "Where I have encountered virtue, I have always encountered against-nature."⁷ It is exactly like this: nature is the world in which the big fish eats the

small one. It is not at all a place of laws. Virtue is different as it is determined not by nature but by culture. It is also something that transcends. In this sense, emancipation actually consists in pursuing secularization, which is to say, emancipation relies on the process of desacralization, in having a better understanding of the spiritual sense of Scriptures by reading them *spiritually*. Max Weber explained that the capitalist world founded itself on the basis of a certain interpretation of Protestant ethics. Thrift, self-discipline, saving, repressing one's immediate impulses are all fundamental to the constitution of the order of capital. As such, the modern world has been formed by applying, transforming, and sometimes even mistaking the content of its tradition, which is primarily that of its own biblical heritage.

At what point does this continual process of transformation end? What are its limits? Or have we now reached a point where there are no more limits, where we may simply do whatever it is we like? No, because though the event of Christianity sets in motion the processes of secularization, we may also find in Scripture a limit to secularization, hence a guide to desacralization—namely, that of charity.⁸ If you read the gospels or the fathers of the church carefully, at the end, the only virtue left is always that of charity. From Saint Paul we learn that the three greatest virtues are faith, hope, and love, “but the greatest of these is love.” Even faith and hope will end at one point or another. As Saint Augustine instructs, “Love and do what you want.”

While this is a liberating message, it is also a discomfoting one, in the sense that it suggests, in relation to love, that everything else associated with the tradition and truth of Christianity is dispensable and may rightfully be called mythology. For instance, I do not know if God is really three persons in one, as defined by classical trinitarian theology. It might seem indispensable to think this way, but surely today we would no longer burn as a heretic someone who does not believe in the trinity.

Instead of applying the heavy hand of church authority to enforce doctrinal conformity, today we would invite the dissenters to think about the matter a bit more. But that being said, when one does think about these matters, instead of settling the debate, it oftentimes raises further difficulties. For example, when I think about the masculine language of God as father, I cannot help but wonder why God must be father and not mother or some other form of parenthood. The language of God as father is so obviously an allegoric language. Once you begin down this road, you do not know where you are going to end up.

The question, then, is whether one can still pray the Lord's Prayer after recognizing that even it too is culturally conditioned. My answer is Yes, because, when I pray, I know precisely that the words I am using are not intended to convey some literal truth. I pray these words more for the love of a tradition than I do for the love of some mythic reality. It is like the relationship you have with an aged relative. It is senseless to demand that your grandparents share your political ideas. Certain matters are best when left unsaid. You may have a special respect for their experience and the language they have inherited. In this sense, interpersonal relationships are much more about charity than truth.

Are scientists scientists out of their love for truth or because they love to be inside a scientific community, which allows them to develop certain discourses and in which they find certain interlocutors? Even when a philosopher such as Jürgen Habermas affirms rationality, he admits that rationality consists in introducing arguments that may be reasonably supported in dialogue with others. He does not say that rationality or truth is that which corresponds to the "thing itself."

The notion of truth has changed from Saint Augustine's understanding. But Augustine's turn inward is already a step forward with respect to the notion of objective truth, because once you turn inward you must also try to listen to others like you.

Today, truth is increasingly determined by agreement with others. We have said, "We do not, and perhaps cannot, agree when we have found the truth, but we may say that at least we have found some truth when we have agreed upon something." This also means that in the place of truth we have put charity. It is like what Dostoevsky wrote a century ago, that, if forced to choose between Christ and the truth, he would choose Christ. Contrast this sentiment with what Aristotle had to say about his teacher Plato: "Amicus Plato sed magis amica veritas" (Plato is a friend, but truth is a greater friend).

Throughout the ages inquisitors have sided with Aristotle rather than Dostoyevsky on this sentiment. The result is that, although not all metaphysics have been violent, I would say that all violent people of great dimensions have been metaphysical. If Hitler only hated the Jews of his particular neighborhood, he might have burned up their homes. But how much more dangerous he was because at a certain point he theorized about the general nature of all Jews and thus felt justified in his efforts to exterminate them all. I do not think it is that difficult to understand this. Nietzsche is very explicit in this sense. According to him, metaphysics is itself an act of violence because it wants to appropriate the "most fertile regions," hence of the first principles, in order to dominate and control. The first lines from Aristotle's *Metaphysics* more or less confirm this when he says that the wise is the one who knows all. The wise knows all by knowing its first cause and is thereby thought able to control and determine all its effects. Our tradition is dominated by the idea that if we only had a stable foundation we could move and act more freely. But philosophical foundationalism does not promote freedom. Rather, it is for the purpose of obtaining some desired effect or of consolidating some authority. When someone wants to tell me the absolute truth it is because he wants to put me under his control, under his command. Is it any wonder, then, that we hear

the refrain “Be a man” or “Do your duty” whenever it is those who are in power send others off to war?

Where is this discourse going with regard to Christianity? Recently I participated in a debate in Turin on Gadamer, who had died only one year before. Many years ago Gadamer was my teacher. Some have said that in recent years Gadamer had developed some sort of religious hermeneutical attitude. This was seen in his frequent dialogues on religion and between religious traditions. In addition, he spoke increasingly about goodness. This religious turn in his philosophy was fundamentally a result of his hermeneutics. That is to say, if there is no objective truth given to someone once and for all, a truth around which we must all (for good or bad, willingly or unwillingly) gather, then truth happens in dialogue. The truth Christ came to teach the church is not an already accomplished truth. Its message grows with history. Similarly, you cannot read Plato without taking into consideration the whole history of interpretation of Plato. What seems natural is in fact historical. After all, is it any surprise that when a middle school student sits down to write poetry his poems sound just like those of Giovanni Pascoli?⁹ Here is where Nietzsche’s hermeneutics of suspicion is helpful: if there is anything that appears to you to be absolutely self-evident, you must distrust it. It is probably some joke that has been inserted in your brain. You can be certain of everything besides your most treasured certainties, because it was probably your aunts, grandparents, churches, authorities, and media that taught them to you and remain most invested in keeping you from second-guessing.

As I see it, Christianity is moving in a direction that cannot but lighten or weaken its moral load in favor of its practical-moral charity. And not only the weakening of its moral-metaphysical assumptions, but, by this transformation, charity will eventually replace truth. After all, are Catholics really supposed to fight, first with the Protestants because they do not accept the

Vatican's authority, then eventually with the Buddhist and the Hindus because they do not believe that God is three persons in one? Are we really expected to believe that when the Pope meets up with the Dalai Lama he worries that the Dalai Lama will end up in hell because he is not Catholic? No, they discuss how to mutually advance the spiritual dimension in human life, and they probably make deals on many things.

The future of Christianity, and also of the Church, is to become a religion of pure love, always more purified. There is a church hymn that states this succinctly and that also helps us see how far off we are from realizing this promise: "Where there is love, there is also God." As this hymn shows, my reading of Christianity is really not that strange or unorthodox. As Christ states: "When two or more of you are gathered in my name" (I cannot help but wonder whether, when Christ says in "my name," he might just as well mean charity), "I am with them." Charity is the presence of God. It is difficult to imagine that at the end some will be damned because they are Buddhist and others Muslims, etc. I say, on the contrary, that we will be damned—or more precisely, we damn ourselves on earth—when we clash against one another, each believing that they have the one true god.

By saying this, I am not putting forth the usual message of tolerance. Instead, I am speaking of the ideal development of human society, hence the progressive reduction of all rigid categories that lead to opposition, including those of property, blood, family, along with the excesses of absolutism. The truth that shall set us free is true precisely because it frees us. If it does not free us, we ought to throw it away. Hence I refuse to admit that this (weak thought, with everything it means) is only a specious kind of preaching (as, in part, it is—I'm after all an interpreter) tolerance. It is much more than that, as a future project that contributes to the progressive elimination of walls (e.g., wall

of Berlin, natural laws configured as a wall that limits the freedom of individuals, the self-interested law of corporations that erects a wall between its success and the social good).

By recovering this message of charity, it allows for the lightening of the dogmatic burden and a new spirit of ecumenism to fill the church. Of course, this is also the message of hermeneutics, of Gadamer, and of so much of contemporary philosophy—all of which have come to be reasonably well accepted. Now it is time for Christianity to realize this nonreligious destiny, which is its own.

Spectral Hermeneutics

On the Weakness of God and the Theology of the Event

JOHN D. CAPUTO

A Theology of the Event

Events

One way to put what postmodernism means is to say that it is a philosophy of the event, and one way to put what a radical or postmodern theology means is to say it is a theology of the event. Obviously, then, on such an accounting, everything depends upon what we mean by an event, which, for the sake of simplicity, I describe as follows. 1. An event is not precisely what happens, which is what the word suggests in English, but something going on *in* what happens, something that is being expressed or realized or given shape in what happens; it is not something present, but something seeking to make itself felt in what is present. 2. Accordingly, I would distinguish between a *name* and the event that is astir or that transpires in a name. The name is a kind of provisional formulation of an event, a relatively stable if evolving structure, while the event is ever restless, on the move, seeking new forms to assume, seeking to get expressed in still unexpressed ways. Names are historical, contingent, provisional expressions

in natural languages, while events are what names are trying to form or formulate, nominate or denominate. 3. An event is not a *thing* but something astir in a thing. Events get realized in things, take on actuality and presence there, but always in a way that is provisional and revisable, while the restlessness and flux of things is explained by the events they harbor. 4. What happens, be it a thing or a word, is always *deconstructible* just in virtue of events, which are not deconstructible. That does not mean that events are eternally true like a Platonic *eidos*; far from being eternally true or present, events are never present, never finished or formed, realized or constructed, whereas only what is constructed is deconstructible. Words and things are deconstructible, but events, if there are any such things (*s'il y en a*), are not deconstructible. 5. In terms of their temporality, events, never being present, solicit us from afar, draw us on, draw us out into the future, calling us hither. Events are provocations and promises, and they have the structure of what Derrida calls the unforeseeable “to come” (*à venir*). Or else they call us back, recall us to all that has flowed by into the irremissible past, which is why they form the basis of what Johann Baptist Metz calls “dangerous memories” of the injustice suffered by those long dead, or not so long, a revocation that constitutes another provocation. Events call and recall.¹

Events are what Žižek calls the “fragile absolute”—when Žižek leaves off abusing postmodern theories he often serves up excellent postmodern goods—fragile because they are delicate and absolute because they are precious.² Events are tender shoots and saplings, the most vulnerable growths, a nascent and incipient stirring, which postmodern thinking must exert every effort to cultivate and keep safe. Postmodernism is the garden-
ing of the event, the thinking of the event, offering events shelter and safe harbor. Events are menaced by great monsters who feed on their tender pulp, by large and overarching theories that would catch them in their sweep, organize them, make them

march in step to some metaphysical tune or other, right or left, theistic or atheistic, idealist or materialist, realist or antirealist. Events, on the other hand, travel close to the surface of what happens, lying low on the plane of immanence, far beneath the radar of big theories like the history of the Absolute Spirit or the Destiny of Being (*Seinsgeschichte*). Events are little gifts, and postmodern thinking seeks to keep them free of big deals, which would sell them out.

On my accounting, things take a *theological turn* in postmodernism when what we mean by the event shifts to God. Or, alternately, things take a *postmodern turn* in theology when the meditation upon *theos* or *theios*, God or the divine, is shifted to events, when the location of God or what is divine about God is shifted from what happens, from constituted words and things, to the plane of events. When events take on the specific look or sound or feel of the sacred, when the sparks we experience in words and things are sacred sparks, divine promptings, or holy intensities, then we have stepped upon the terrain of postmodern theology.³ Think of the event as a fire, a flame, even as what Deleuze does not hesitate to call its “eternal truth”! Fire, flames, and sparks have from time out of mind been figures of the divine. To cite but one very famous example, Meister Eckhart said there is a little spark in the soul (*ein Seelenfünkeln*), which is the point where God and the soul touch. In postmodern theology the event lends things, we might say, a kind of divine glow, what Deleuze calls a brightness and splendor, “the splendor of Being.” Theology keeps its ear close to the heart of the pulses or pulsations of the divine in things.

However postmodern, a theology of the event has an ancient pedigree, going back to a famous narrative about a very seminal event indeed, whose punch line was that life glows with the “good” that Elohim pronounced upon creation—six times, the final time emphasizing the point in case we missed it: *very good*. For if we look closely at just what Elohim did in the first creation

story in Genesis, we will quickly notice that it did not consist in drawing being out of nothing, as the metaphysical theologians would have us think, but in putting the glow of life and light upon what was dark and lifeless, charging it, sparking it, lighting it up, we might say with the splendor and brightness of life. It was as if the great elements—the womblike deep (*tehom*), the formless void (*tobu wa bobu*), and the wind (*ruach*) were sleeping, and Elohim's word was a call to them to awaken and glow with life. On this alternate account of creation, what Elohim did was to release the events that stirred within these great sleeping elements.

We might even say, to put all this in a bold and simple stroke, that in postmodern theology what happens to us is God, which is why we call it postmodern *theology*. Or, to couch it in a slightly more cautious terms, in postmodern theology what happens to us is the *event* that is harbored in the name of God, which is why we want to cultivate the resources in this name, to nurture and shelter them, and to let us ourselves be nourished by their force, made warm by their glow, charged by their intensities.⁴ The crucial move lies in treating the event as something that is going on *in* words and things, as a potency that stirs within them and makes them restless with the event. Deleuze says that to will the event means more precisely to will “not exactly what occurs but something *in* that which occurs, something yet to come which would be consistent with what occurs.” “The event is not what occurs (an accident), it is rather inside what occurs, the purely expressed. It signals and awaits us.”⁵ That is to head in a more Derridean direction where willing the event means to “affirm” the event, to say “*oui, oui*” (Amen!) not to what is present but to *what is coming*, to what stirs within things, within words and things, to what is *promised* by them.

Then events assume a more messianic or even a ghostly look, for in postmodern theology we believe in ghosts, very holy if slightly pale ghosts called events, which are the stuff of what I am

calling here a spectral hermeneutics. Then one has turned one's face to the future and one is haunted by the possibilities harbored in events—by the fragile “perhaps” in things—which promise a new life, a new being, a new creation. We replace *amor fati*, which is one of those big stories that threatens to quash the fragile absolute of the event, with an *amor venturi*, a love or affirmation of what is to come, which makes more sense.⁶ For all of us, everyone from Deleuze to evangelical Bible-thumpers, want to be born again.⁷ For Deleuze, the event is a kind of anonymous impulse, a prepersonal transcendental field, a nomad that moves freely across the border that separates words and things, essence and existence, or else it is the very “surface” that joins and separates them. The event constitutes a transcendental archi-sense (which Deleuze somewhat misleadingly calls non-sense) that makes garden variety sense and non-sense both possible and impossible. If so, then what is distinctive about postmodern theology is that this prepersonal, prehuman field is taken to be a domain of the divine, a sacred surface that is lined with divine strings of force or sparked by divine impulses or charged with divine intensities.⁸

A Postmodern Covenant

In thinking of radical theology as a theology of the event, the stress is on the event as an irreducible possibility, a potentiality that can assume various forms of expression and instantiation. The event is not reducible to the actual, but stirs as a simmering potentiality within the name or the state of affairs, incessantly seeking an outlet, constantly pressing for expression in words and things. The event is irreducible; indeed, I am inclined to say that it is the very form of irreducibility itself. For what is irreducible is what resists contraction into some finite form or other, what seeks to twist free from the finite containers in which it finds itself

deposited, what cannot be contained—which is what we *mean* by the event. Whenever we encounter an occurrence like a word or a thing, a proposition or a state of affairs, a belief or a practice, a discourse or an institution that cannot contain what it contains, that is because of the event it contains, because it is astir with the event, because it has been shocked, shaken, and disturbed by the event, which is seeking to twist free from its present confinement. Indeed, that is also how I would put deconstruction in a nutshell. For what else is deconstruction but the work of analyzing phenomena that contain what they cannot contain in order to release the event they (cannot) contain?

The event is not so much something present as something coming, something stirring, something signaling us from afar, something waiting for us to catch up, something inviting, promising, provoking, and, let us say, for this is a word that packs a special punch in theology, something *promised*. When Derrida speaks of the “democracy to come,” that phrase refers to the event of something coming that is presently astir in the word *democracy*, something that invites and calls us in this word, which is the least bad word we have at present for something given to us now only by an anticipated grace, that is, in our prayers and tears. This is how the event is capable of taking a religious form and just why it provides the stuff of a theology of the event. For the event constitutes a kind of *covenant* that has been cut with us, which makes us the people of the promise, of the covenant, of the cut. *Religion* is the covenant that has been made—by whom we cannot quite say—between the event and us. So beyond—or perhaps *within*—the Jewish and the Christian Covenants, let us dream of a postmodern covenant, where we are the people of the event, the ones called together by the event.

Still, by speaking of the “religious” form taken by the event, have I not endangered this tender sapling by exposing it to the Monster or Master Narrative of Religion, whose history in the

West is one of violence and bloodshed? Have I not baldly betrayed the irreducible event by reducing it to the religions of the Book, the ones constituted by the Covenant that has been cut between God and his chosen people, which are famous for their monotheistic exclusivism and jealousy? I will be your God and you will be my people, and we will not allow any foreign gods or infidels to disturb this intimacy of this private relation. It is for this reason that I insist that the event is not what occurs but something *in* what occurs, something stirring, something still to come. The idea behind a postmodern theology is to *release the event* that stirs in the famous covenantal scenes and not allow it to be contracted to any present form or constricted by its local conditions.⁹ The event is the *unconditional* that is astir in these local conditions, what is undeconstructible in any historical construction or discursive practice. If I take “religion” in its most radical sense as a covenant cut between the event and its people, my intention is to avail the event of the most flexible form available to safeguard its irreducibility. To say that the event has a religious sense is to underline something crucial in it, which is the *unconditional passion* or the *passion for the unconditional* that the event engenders. In the Scriptures the covenant is a promise or a covenant cut by *God*—that is why I speak unabashedly of *theology*—where the name of God is the name of an event, of something that stirs within that name, something I know not what, some sacred spark or fire. The name of God shelters an event, and the task of thinking about or meditating upon this name is to safeguard that event and release what is stirring there. The name of God is very simply the most famous and richest name we have to signify both an open-ended excess and an inaccessible mystery. That is why I insist I do not “reduce” the event to religion when I speak of a theology of the event but on the contrary find a place to safeguard its irreducibility and unconditionality. The name of God is the name of one of

humanity's most famous fires, one that has inflamed humankind from time immemorial—which explains why, like every fire, it is also so dangerous. Affirming the eternal flame of the event that burns within the name of God is also a way to flag the consuming violence that is stored up in this name.

The name of God is one of the names that Derrida has in mind when he meditates upon the phrase *sauf le nom*, “safe the name,” an expression that for Derrida means both: let us keep this name safe, let us save it, but also: God is everything save (*sauf*/except) the name, save or except what the name names explicitly, everything except the excess that exceeds what is explicitly named. The name of God names everything save the event that is sheltered by this name, which is an event that solicits and invites, calls and signals us, but is never finally named.¹⁰

The affirmation of the event is less an agency than a responsiveness, less a subjectivistic decisionism than accepting the terms of a covenant. For what else can the affirmation of the event be but the response of a subject to a visitation by something that overtakes it? What else can such an affirmation be but the responsibility by which the subject is organized or galvanized into a subject of the event? What else is the event than the fire that inflames the movement of the subject or what Derrida calls the decision of the other in me? To affirm the name of God is to say yes to the forces that work their way through that name and traverse our hearts and bodies. For the event is what calls us and we are the people of the call, the people of the event who want to make themselves worthy of the call.

Prayers and Tears

Religion begins and ends with prayer; where there is prayer, there is religion; where there is religion, there is prayer. Now

the event is the stuff of which prayers and tears are made, that by which we are always already solicited, invited, called. The event is always already ahead of us, always provoking and soliciting us, eternally luring us on with its promise. The truth of the event is its promise to come true. Events make promises that are never kept by any actual occasion. That is also what I have been calling the irreducibility of the event. The event can never be held captive by any particular instance of the event, never reduced to any present form or instantiation. It would be the height of injustice, not to say of arrogance, to say that justice is finally realized in some existing form, in some present person or state. The unconditional event is only conditionally realized in any time or place, in any word or proposition or discursive formation, in any ontic realization or actualization. The irreducible event is what reduces us to tears, to prayers and tears, for its coming. The event is what destabilizes all such relatively stable structures as attempt to house it, making them restless with the future, teeming with hope and promise, even as it is in virtue of the event that things are haunted by the past, made an occasion of dangerous memories, which are no less unnerving and destabilizing. The eternal truth of the event is its nomadism, its restless journey across barren deserts, or perhaps its venturing upon uncharted seas, in any case, its discontent with more sedimented, sedentary formations, even as the ancient charge that is laid upon us by the nomad is hospitality, to throw wide the door of welcome to its coming. Not only to welcome its coming but to pray and weep over its arrival.

Theology is a place where the energies of the event may be nurtured and released, its intensities cultivated and affirmed, built up and discharged—free from all the constraints of what exists. *Alice in Wonderland* and the stories of Borges suffer very little disadvantage from having to do with nonexistent entities, a point that Deleuze makes throughout *The Logic of Sense*, which

on my reading is also a bit of a cryptotheologic of sense.¹¹ Nor does prayer, as we do not pray for what already exists, unless we are praying for it to go away and exist no more. Indeed, such inexistence is the condition of the range and power of literature and prayer, of sense itself. Literature and theology are places where we dream of what is coming, where we pray and weep for something that eye has not yet beheld nor ear heard, where we venture upon the plane of what does not exist and wonder indeed why not. I think that on the whole such inexistence constitutes a very upbeat and affirmative definition of theology; every genuine affirmation of God must pass through a dark night and mandatory atheism. Whenever Derrida speaks of the event, which turns on what is undeconstructible, he adds the precaution *s'il y en a*, "if there is any"! For if whatever exists is deconstructible, then the event, which is undeconstructible, lies just beyond the reach and across the borders of what exists, which is the special province of a postmodern theology.

Indeed, there is even something of a classical ring, a paradoxically Anselmian tonality in this formula. The name of God is the name of an event that is greater than anything that exists.¹² If anything does exist, that is not what is named by the name of God, or, rather, it is not the event that is harbored or contained within the name of God. For the very meaning of the event is to prevent the name or the thing from blocking or containing the intensity of the event within. When something happens that contains an event, it contains precisely what it cannot contain. To exist would mean to exhaust the event, which means the event that is named in or under the name of God can never take final form, can never exist and exhaust itself on the ontical or ontological plane, neither in some highest being up above nor even in Being itself, even as it can never be conceived in some logically adequate expression or concept. The event that stirs within the name of God is always soliciting us and inviting us,

calling and signaling us. We do not properly say of this event that it exists but that it solicits and calls to us from within what exists, which is why events are a matter of prayers and tears. Prayer is not a transaction or interaction with some hyperbeing in the sky, a communication with some ultrareality behind the scenes, the invocation or appeasement of a magical power of supernatural intervention from on high. Prayer has to do with hearing, heeding, and hearkening to a provocation that draws us out of ourselves.¹³

The Desire for God

To speak of our prayers and tears is but another way to speak of our desire, and to speak of our desire is to enter a never-never land more outlandish than anything Alice ever ran into down that rabbit hole, for desire is situated in the space between, or perhaps it is the very spacing between, what exists and what does not exist. Desire is nourished and fed by what does not exist, by the power of what does not exist to solicit and disturb us, which is why desire has ultimately to do with events. To speak of desire is to address all that we are and are not, all that we know and do not know, which means an enigma wrapped in a secret so deep that it can never be known by us or by anyone else, which is why Derrida calls it the absolute secret. Because desire has to do with the event, we do not know what we desire, but this nonknowing is what keeps desire alive. If the event would be exhausted by existence, by existing in full, it would be exterminated by the white light of knowledge.

We should never give up on our desire, as Lacan says, upon which Badiou comments, “For desire is constitutive of the subject of the unconscious; it is thus the non-known *par excellence*, such that ‘do not give up on your desire’ rightly means: ‘do not

give up on that part of yourself that you do not know.’”¹⁴ I would put the same idea by saying that our desire is for the Messiah who never shows up, which is what keeps desire going. Unless in a futile attempt to get some peace and quiet we give up. But if we give up on desire, that will succeed only in making us miserable. For then one part of us, the part of us that we know, gives up while the other part, the part of us that we do not know, has not given up. That will not bring us inner peace but the inner illness of the sickness unto death.

From time immemorial the name of God has been the name of what we desire, with a desire beyond desire, so one way to try to give up altogether is to give up on God—or to try. The name of God is not precisely the name of what we desire but the name of the event that occurs *in* what we desire that keeps desire alive. Whenever we desire this or that determinate thing, it is true that that indeed is what we desire. But that is not the whole truth; it is not the final form in which our desire can take shape. For were the thing that we desire delivered, that would only feed desire all the more, and were, God forbid, that thing or person dashed, that would not, or need not, dash our desire, for desire can never be reduced to that determinate occasion. Our desire is irreducible because the event, which is what we desire, is irreducible. To speak of making ourselves worthy of the event means that we spend our lives, or so we should, trying to make ourselves worthy of what we desire. We spend our lives, or so we should, hoping, dreaming, sighing for the event, praying and weeping over the event, praying for the coming of the event. For the event does not quite, never does exactly—*exist*. If theology is the science of nonexistent entities, it is because theology is born in the space between what exists and the event, which means that theology is born in prayer. That is its great dignity, its glorious body, which pulses through and animates the language of Saint Augustine’s *Confessions*. The name of God is as old and venerable

and hoary a name as we have for desire, for our desire beyond desire. “*Inquietum est cor nostrum*,” our heart is made restless with this desire, “*donec requiescat in te*,” and our heart will not rest until it rests in you, in the event that this “you” embodies.

What do I desire? Who or what is desiring within me? That, by the very terms of what we mean by desire and event, cannot finally be formulated. Of course, this is only the half of it. For the issue of our inability to give our desire any *final* formulation is a steady flow of provisional formulations.¹⁵ We are all along in the dark about what we desire, about what is desiring us, about what is desiring *in* us. But this darkness keeps desire safe from the withering sun of knowledge. “*Quid ergo amo, cum deum meum amo?*” Derrida asks with Augustine (*Conf.* 10:6–7). What do I love when I love my God? What do I desire when I desire God? What is the event of desire that takes place in me, that makes its place in me, here in this place where I say “I.” What is the event of desire, which is always the desire for the event, that occurs in theology?

The Weakness of God

The event jolts the world, disturbs, disrupts, and skews the sedimented course of things, exposing the alternate possibilities that course their nomadic way through the normalized quotidian paths that things routinely follow. That is one reason we read literature, and that is why Deleuze takes so much joy in the works of Lewis Carroll, and well he should. I am only puzzled—well, not really puzzled, but disappointed—that he did not notice another literature—and here he differs from Derrida—no less anarchical and chaomic, an anarchy no less crowned, but this time with a sacred crown, the sacred anarchy of the “Kingdom of God.” I am disappointed that he did not pursue the fountain

of events that issues in the mad, paradoxical, parabolical, upside down, topsy-turvy world that is to be found in the Scriptures. For if postmodern thinking is intent on following the movements of the events by which words and things are inwardly disturbed, by which they are even driven slightly mad, we theologians of the event are here to insist that madness is of many kinds. To the bright and witty giddiness of Alice of Wonderland and the dark pain of schizophrenia mapped by Deleuze we add a third: the divine madness of the Kingdom of God described in the New Testament, where the event provokes the most sublime effects, a veritable “sacred anarchy,” whose parables and paradoxes are easily the match of any of the tales told by Lewis Carroll. It is precisely this impossible circulation of such divine events that gives rise to a story like the wedding feast that is every bit as odd as a party thrown by a Mad Hatter.

Deleuze should have suspected an event there. He should have wondered whether the zany reversals and astonishing paradoxes in the New Testament were any less the offspring of an event than is the tale of a tardy rabbit darting down a hole. What marvelous stream of events has left its traces on this surface and marked this surface with such vivid and unforgettable figures? But, for the most part, the New Testament remained for him a missed opportunity, and he allowed himself to be waylaid by the received institutional reading of the text and discouraged by the high wall of ecclesiastical power by which it is surrounded. So one way for a postmodern theology to proceed—and there are several; I make no claim to have a corner on the market—is to feel about for the event that has so disturbed the surface of these stories. What intensities, what nomadic bit of nonsense or archi-sense there throws everything into reverse? What flow of forces issues in such unforgettable madness, in such sacred foolishness, where people make themselves fools for the Kingdom of God?

Sacred Anarchy

My thesis is twofold. 1. In the Scriptures the odd phenomena constituting the “Kingdom of God” are the offspring of the shock that is delivered by the name of God to what is there called the “world,” resulting in what I call a “sacred anarchy.” Consider but a sampling of its more salient features. In the Kingdom, the last are first and first are last, a strategically perverted system of privileging, so that the advantage is given not to beautiful Athenian bodies that house a love of wisdom, but to lepers, deaf mutes, the blind, epileptics, and the paralyzed. The favor of the Kingdom falls not on men of practical wisdom, of *arete*, of experts in *phronesis*, but on tax collectors and prostitutes, who enjoy preferential treatment over the upright and well behaved. In addition, in the Kingdom the way to be arrayed with all the glory of God is to neither sow nor reap but to behave like the lilies of the field. If you try to save your life you will lose it, but if you lose it you will be saved. In the Kingdom one should hate one’s father and mother but love one’s enemies, and if a man strikes you you should offer him the other cheek. There, if you are rich, you have a very fine needle indeed to thread to get into the Kingdom. If you would want to become rich with the treasures offered by this Kingdom, you should sell all that you have and give it to the poor. Moreover, you should give to the poor not only what you can afford but even what you need for yourself. If one of your sheep is lost, then you should not worry about endangering the other ninety-nine but go out and search for the lost one, which is an unaccountably odd way to count. If you host a party—even a wedding for one of your children—you should go out into the streets and welcome in the passers by. These bodies pass easily through solid walls, rise from the dead, traverse the surface of water without sinking, glow with a blinding whiteness, and pass instantly from one state, like water, into another, like wine.

Cripples are made straight, lepers are cured, and the dead rise from their grave. All these bodily metamorphoses are in turn figures of a personal transformation best described as *metanoia*, which might be retranslated from “repentance” to “being of a new mind and heart,” being tuned and attuned to the new being that comes of belonging to the Kingdom.

2. The event that shocks the world is not a strong but a weak force. Underlying, or arching over, all these famous paradoxes, there is, on my hypothesis, a thesis about God, or about the event that is harbored in the name of God, one that is contrary to the powers that be in theology and the church, a startling thesis found in what Paul calls “the weakness of God.”¹⁶ Saint Paul puts this thesis about weakness very powerfully, even paradigmatically, in a veritably Deleuzian discourse on the “logos of the cross (*logos tou staurou*),” the mark of which Paul identifies as “foolishness.” Here, in a virtuoso performance of the interweaving of sense and non-sense, of a *logos* that is the offspring of *morìa*, Paul spells out the way this weakness jolts the world: God chose the foolish ones in the world to shame the wise, and what is weak to shame the strong, and what is the low down in the world, the ones who “are not” (*ta me onta*), to shame the men of *ousia*, men of substance, the powers that be. The “weakness of God,” Paul says, is stronger than human strength (I Cor. 1:25).¹⁷

A Postmodern Theology of the Cross

A good deal of what is going on in these texts comes back to a certain event, to a disturbing experience of God as a “weak force,” and it is this crucial paradox that incites such a riot of reversals and paradoxes in its narratives. This crucial event is paradigmatically expressed in the Cross, where Jesus is subject-

ed to an excruciating and humiliating execution as a common criminal, defeated by Roman power, deserted by the disciples and even forsaken by God.¹⁸ Jesus was crucified, not freely, but against his will, against the will of everything that is good and just, human or divine. Jesus was the spokesman of a message about the coming of the Kingdom, which delivered the shock of the event to the world, for which the world made him pay with his blood. Blood is the coin of the realm in the world, not in the Kingdom. Blood is how things are done in the world, for the ways of the world are the ways of power. When Peter raises his sword to prevent Jesus from being taken by the Roman guards in the Garden, Jesus tells him to put it down, for that is not how things happen in the Kingdom. If we take from this that Jesus could, with a wave of his hand or a wink of his eye, demolish these Roman soldiers but freely chose not to exert his omnipotence because he was on a divine mission, then we would concede that he merely seems, *docet*, to be a helpless and innocent victim of this power. But that is what he was in truth. The radical uprooting of the heresy of Docetism demands that we locate the divinity of this scene of misery and defeat, the sacredness of its memory, not in some hidden divine power play or long-term investment in a divine economy of salvation. The sacredness lies in the cries of protest that rise up from the scene. The event to be willed here is the depth of outrage at the injustice of imperial power, of the crushing of the Kingdom by worldly forces. The divinity lies in the identification of the name of God, for Jesus was the *eikon* of God, not with Roman power but with an innocent victim of that power, not with retribution but with the act of *forgiveness* that is attributed to Jesus by the evangelists. The ways of a father in the Kingdom are illustrated by the story of another father, the one who was prodigal with his love of his prodigal son. Those are the ways of the Kingdom. In the world, violence is met with counterviolence; in the Kingdom it is met

I would press further to a more pressing and important death, the death of the *deus omnipotens* of classical theology, and this in order to nourish the life of the event that stirs within the name of God, which is the stuff of our rebirth. The death of the God of power gives birth to what Sallie McFague calls the “body of God,” to God’s suffering body, which rises up in unconditional protest against needless and unjust suffering. Insofar as there is any philosophical life left in this increasingly dated expression, the death of God, it refers to an ongoing and never finished project of deconstructing the God of ontotheologic, which is for me above all the God of sovereign power. I am always interested in loosening up the events that stir within beliefs and practices that have gained too much grip on us, whose prestige threatens to intimidate us, which have grown into big theories and big stories, big deals and big pains, which bring along with themselves a history of intimidation, oppression, and violence. And, God help us, that is certainly true of the name of God. The more some people use the word *God* the more I find myself praying to God for the death of God, asking God to rid us of God, to cite a very famous mystic. There is surely something to be gained from undertaking a deconstruction of the name of God precisely under the auspices of a “death” of God. To this campaign I make modest annual contributions, just so long as this is understood to be a way of affirming the event that lives within the name of God. For with Deleuze and Saint Paul—and the Bible-thumpers—I too want to be born again, at least once before I die. The work of burning off the old metaphysics of omnipotence, which can never cease, must always be a way to fan the flame or build the fire of the event that transpires in the name of God. Mark Taylor’s famously downbeat description of deconstruction as “a hermeneutic of the death of God” is but a moment in a more upbeat description of the theology of the event as a “hermeneutics of the desire for God.”²²

what I call by a certain analogy weak theology, which turns on the weakness of God that is expressed for me in the death of Jesus. There are other ways to do what I am doing here, but mine is confessedly Christian, and it is the point at which my theology of the event converges with the thought of Vattimo.

I have an inner sympathy with Vattimo's work on more than one count.

Like Vattimo, I am a Catholic and an Italian—well, a weak Italian, a quasi-Italian, a simulacrum of an Italian, an Italian American who does not speak Italian, two generations removed from the ancestral city of Napoli, and no doubt an even weaker Catholic. As such, I share with him a common intellectual culture and a common education in the great medieval metaphysical theologies. Like Vattimo, Jacques Maritain was an early hero for me, and I was from the start suspicious of modernist dogmas. When I first read *Being and Time*, I thought, here is what I am looking for, a way to critique modernity which is not a narrow-minded antimodern Catholicism but the very latest thing in European phenomenology! Like Vattimo, I feel a common outrage at the pontifical authoritarianism and “fundamentalism”²⁵ of John Paul II and I would be astonished if anything different emerged from Benedict XVI. If the late pope was a lovely man who lent a hand in bringing down the reign of terror in Communist east Europe, he was also an administrator who installed his own form of terror within the Roman Catholic Church. John Paul II virtually extinguished every trace of the notion of the “people of God” that was the hallmark of the Second Vatican Council and thoroughly betrayed the spirit of that great council. He set back the legitimate aspirations of women in the Church a generation, intimidated Catholic scholars and free speech with inquisitorial violence, and left behind a Church in which it is impossible to imagine that its dangerous and reactionary teachings on birth control and homosexuality will be corrected in the

siero debole). Kenosis, as the transcription, translation, or transmission of God into the world, means establishing the kingdom of God on earth. This is an idea whose political correlate is a nonauthoritarian democracy and whose epistemic correlate is a Gadamerian vision of dialogue and horizon-fusion, where, as Gadamer says, “Being that is understood is language”—and conversation. Weakening then is Vattimo’s more radical version of hermeneutics.

The Christian church should accordingly reconsider its critique of an increasingly secular culture, and, instead of lamenting defeat at the hands of secularization, it should declare victory and march home in triumph. For what else is Western culture than the translation of otherworldly Christianity into terrestrial structures, the conversion of its celestial currency into the coin of the more benign ethical, social, political, and even economic institutions of the Western world? The weakening of Being (Heidegger) has made “Christianity” once again a legible, credible story, one that we can take seriously, and secularization has transcribed that story from unreadable myth into legible history. In secular culture the old religious narratives are published in a new edition, translated into the secular vernacular in an affordable paperback. There they are no longer tales told about transcendent transactions in eternity but stories about the *saeculum*, the historical time in which real people live. There is thus a “family resemblance” between the weakening of Being and the rebirth of religion, an essential correlation.³¹ With the withering away of metaphysics, which was given ample opportunity to prove its worth and whose only result was an arid and reifying rationality that turned the world and human life into objects for instrumental reason, we are free to return for nourishment to the old religious narratives.

For example, for Vattimo, the commonplace complaint that the secular world has taken the Christ out of Christmas and

transcribed it into “Happy Holidays” is to be viewed as still another success on Christianity’s part. For now the Incarnation, a theological doctrine accepted in a strong or robust form only within confessional limits, has been translated into a popular secular holiday in the West, in which the spirit of generosity and goodwill among all people prevails. During the “holidays” this attenuated if wispy “spirit” of love becomes general among humankind, which is what in fact this doctrine actually “means,” its application in the concrete reality of lived experience. The tolerant, nonauthoritarian and pluralistic democratic societies in the West are the translation into real political structures of the Christian doctrine of neighbor love. When the transcendent God is “weakened”—or emptied—into the world, it assumes the living form of Western cultural life. Vattimo shows that this schema, which modernity first learned from Hegel and Schelling, and was deployed by Altizer and the 1960s movement, is found in its earliest form in Joachim of Fiores’s millennialist doctrine of the “three ages,” that of the Father (Judaism), the Son (the New Testament), and the Spirit, which is the unfolding of the Kingdom of God on earth from the year 1000 on. Western history for Vattimo is the *Wirkungsgeschichte* of a “classic” in the Gadamerian sense, of the New Testament, its unfolding life and application, its developing revelation and realization, translation and transcription.³² But in Vattimo the age of the Spirit is not a version of metaphysics, not the biography of the Absolute in time, as it is in Joachim, Hegel, and Altizer, which is strong thinking, but an interpretive schema, a way to put the realization that we have always to do with conflicting interpretations whose only measure is love without measure.

The task of intellectuals today is therefore twofold. On the hand, they must move beyond the old reductionism and objectivisms of the nineteenth century and take the hermeneutic turn. In such a world the old religious narratives have once again to

be taken seriously as irreducible language games or forms of life that uniquely instruct us about the meaning of our lives. On the other, the task of the intellectual is firefighting, that is, to see that while the flame of such religious narratives is kept alive it does not burn out of control. While the stories are to be taken seriously, they are not to be taken literally, which would issue in the worst sort of fundamentalism, the worst hardening of theology into authoritarianism and dogma, as opposed to its weakening into pluralism and hospitality.³³

“The West or Christianity”

While I am full of admiration for Vattimo’s bracing and embracing hermeneutics, I have certain reservations that turn on the privilege “Christianity” enjoys in his work, as when he boldly uses the “provocative” expression “the West or Christianity,” which he takes as an inclusive not an exclusive disjunction,³⁴ as if to thwart the way Heidegger tended to see the “West” as “the Greeks” and to treat “Christianity” as a fall from the authentically Greek. It is a generalization of Weber’s thesis that capitalism grows out of the spirit of Protestantism; capitalism and democracy, science and technology are the applied or secularized truth of “Christianity,”³⁵ ways of “achieving our religion,” to adapt the title of a book by Richard Rorty, Vattimo’s recent dialogue companion. What Vattimo and Rorty mean by achieving our country or achieving our religion (Christianity), is realizing the universal ideals that each emblemize. Christianity is to be superseded as a particular sect and taken as a (privileged) stand-in for universal hospitality to the stranger; the United States is to be taken not as a unilateral player in the power games of world politics but as standing for the ideals affirmed in the Declaration of Independence and the Constitution. Up to now, Vattimo says,

Christianity has been part of the problem, but if it would understand itself correctly it would become the basis of the solution,³⁶ because Christianity means love, and if love, then hospitality and pluralism. My concern is that there is an unguardedness in talk like this, considering that each time different people use these expressions, like “our” country or religion, they mean different countries and different religions. While it is productive to frame things that way in an in-house debate among Americans or among Christians, in order to make sure that the doors of hospitality are held open, it is riskier business to talk this way on a global stage, in the international community, where many countries and religions are in play.

But, beyond the rhetorical limitations, there is a substantive problem: Judaism gets *aufgehoben* in this expression, absorbed and assimilated into “Christianity,” which is asked to do service for Judaism, asked to remember all the specific contributions of the Jewish in “Christianity,” or in the “Judaeo-Christian,” deploying the famous “hypen” that was the subject of Lyotard’s book. I do not think that Jews will be reassured by this strategy any more than feminists would be reassured by a male philosopher who would assure them that every time he said the “rights of man” he was also including women. Why not either make one’s discourse more complicated or even, in a gesture of strategic reversal, let *women* or *Jews* serve as the universal emblem—as in “Athens and Jerusalem”—something that Vattimo could do if he is invoking a broadly biblical tradition, if what he ultimately means is the translation of God into neighbor love. But the problem is substantive, not rhetorical. It lies in Vattimo’s implication that this schema cannot be worked out in a Jewish context, which I think is a mistake. He is a critic of the transcendence of God in Levinas, but he does not observe that in Levinas, every time we attempt to direct our glance to God on high it is “deflected” by God to the face of the neighbor here below. The prag-

matic meaning of the transcendence of the *tout autre* in Levinas is service to the neighbor. Levinas's Jewish deflection does the work of Vattimo's Christian kenosis. The very transcendence of God as *tout autre* of which Vattimo complains is *transcribed* into neighborly love: it is precisely because the face of God is transcendent that the only form in which you will ever find the face of God is in the face of the neighbor, which is where you should direct all your attention. Indeed, given that Jesus was a Jew attempting to renew Judaism and with no intention of starting a new religion, that is almost certainly what was behind Jesus's own sayings about neighbor love. But if Vattimo's privileging of Christianity poses a problems for Jews, it does so a fortiori for Islam, where the question of a simmering religious war is even more acute. For the Arab nations the hyphen in *Judeo-Christian* is the name of an ominous political alliance between the state of Israel and the United States. At that point, Vattimo's talk of "Christianity" as the bearer of world hospitality becomes still more questionable—even as it takes a great deal of crust and nose holding to use the words *United States* as the emblem of international hospitality, when it is in fact the emblem of the wasteful overconsumption of the world's resources and the hegemonic exercise of national sovereignty.

This bring us back to the problem that I pointed out above with the death of God theologies—and there is a deep family resemblance between Vattimo's secularization thesis and the death of God theologies. For, however radical they may be, these are theologies with a *Christian* pedigree that turn on the doctrines of the Trinity and the Incarnation. They tend toward a schema that inevitably casts Judaism in a bad light and hence restages what Derrida calls the "duel between Christian and Jew."³⁷ From Joachim of Fiora through Hegel, Schelling, and Feuerbach up to the contemporary death of God thinkers, these theologies always plot the transition from transcendence to immanence, from

alienation and estrangement to homecoming, from God as a distant and severe Father to God first as Son and sibling and then as the spirit of love. Somebody has to play the bad guy (“the religion of the Father”) in this story, and that is inevitably Judaism.³⁸ The death of God is a *grand récit* all its own that is complicitous with Hegel’s story about the Jews and a certain quick reading of Saint Paul on the Jews. That is a supersessionist story of the transition from the alienated Old Law of the Pharisees to the benign New Law of love and the gift, from the dead letter of literalism to the living Spirit, from the legalism of slaves to the religion of the children and friends of God, from an eye-for-an-eye economy to the gift, etc. The hint of Marcion is never far from this story, however much it is resisted and revised.

To be reminded of the violence implicit in this schema one need only read Hegel’s *Spirit of Christianity*, which manages to say the most hateful things about Jews in the course of defining Christianity as the religion of love. Hegel’s metaphysics of the alienated Jews is as much a metaphysics of hate as a metaphysics of love, and it is upon this metaphysics of love/hate that Derrida descends in *Glas*. That is why, rather than serving as its “hermeneutics,” deconstruction does well to keep a safe distance from the death of God theologies. Deconstruction is something more of a Jewish science, that is, a deconstruction of idols that, while affirming flesh and the body—the Jewish Scriptures are all about land and children—is constantly worried about divine incarnations, because incarnations are always *local* occurrences. Deconstruction would always worry about a divine kenosis that resulted in filling up someone’s pocket with the transferred goods of divinity. Because the death of God takes place in a particular time and place, in a particular people and language, it raises the problem of privileged theological access and pits those among whom God has pitched his tent against their Jewish predecessors. Jewish alienation is overcome by a kenotic process conceived as

a zero-sum economy that empties out the Jewish account and transfers its funds to Christian holdings. So difficult is it for this schema to stay clear of this implication of supersessionism that it even shows up in completely secular, atheistic neo-Marxists like Žižek and Badiou when they start singing the praises of love and grace in Saint Paul over the Law, which is death.

Vattimo criticizes what he variously calls existential, tragic, or apocalyptic Christianity. In this version of Christianity, he says, secular history is devalued as senseless and violent and is seen to require an in-breaking revelation from God as *tout autre* to redeem it. Such a view of Christianity is inspired by the “Old Testament faith” or a “theology of the first age”³⁹ and “undervalues” Christ’s incarnation; it goes hand in hand with a “Judaic religiosity” that is “affirmed at the expense of any recognition of novelty in the Christian event.”⁴⁰ The very idea of God as “wholly other,” which has played a leading role in the renewed philosophical interest in religion that has come about because of Levinas and Derrida, he says, is an alienated one, estranged from the genuine sense of kenosis according to which God, instead of maintaining his holiness or separation from the world, empties himself into the world. I do agree with Vattimo’s aim of disarming the metaphysics of apocalypticism, the dualism of two worlds, one immanent, lost, and secular, the other in-breaking, salvific, holy, and wholly other. Like him, like all death of God theology generally, I do affirm the one and only world we know, the one that Elohim declared good five times, then adding, for good measure, “very good.” But I want to preserve the salvific effects of distance, of the shock or trauma of an “unconditional claim” that disrupts the human-all-too-human course of the “world.” I want to preserve not the metaphysics of apocalypticism but the ethicoreligious sense or schema of the event. For the event is not what happens but what is going on *in* what happens that makes it restless with the future. Thus instead of opposing two worlds, or of opposing God and the world as if

these were two realms of being, I distinguish between the world and the event by which the world is disturbed, the unconditional claim that solicits the world from within, that interrupts and summons it, which is what I think deconstruction is (if it *is*). I do not distinguish two different worlds but two different logics, the logic of the mundane constituted economies and the logic of the event that disturbs them, and I see in Jesus of Nazareth an exemplary embodiment of the logic or paralogic of the gift, who told paradoxical parables about and who was himself a parable of the kingdom of God, which he opposed to the economy of the “world.” The event that transpired in Jesus knocked Paul from his horse and delivered a shock to the world. And if I do not pit a supersensible world against a sensible one, neither do I pit Jesus against Judaism. On the contrary, on this point Jesus could not be more Jewish; he does everything he does in the name not of Judaism’s supersession but a renewal of the living doctrine (*Torah*) of neighbor love, which is also found in Levinas’s notion of deflection and still more inclusively in Derrida’s *tout autre est tout autre*.

That is why I cast the theology of the event in terms of a structural analysis of the distinction between the name and the event, or the thing and the event, or between the pure messianic and the concrete messianisms. I do not cast my views in terms of the death of God, or even in terms of the secularization thesis, and I keep a safe distance from the historical periodization in which these theologies are caught up. I object to them on two grounds. First of all, I do not see how it is possible to decontaminate these schemata from supersessionist theories that cast Judaism as a religion of the father and hence as theater of alienation and cruelty, even if one’s personal intentions are certainly not antisemitic.⁴¹ Second, they tend to become grand narratives, overarching a priori histories that are selling us another metaphysical bill of goods under the name of demythologization. That is why they suffer embarrassment and consternation

under the hand of the empirical facts, of the course that history actually takes. The suggestion that traditional orthodox faith in God is somehow on the wane in the United States, which hit the streets in the 1960s as both a sociological and theological thesis, could only be made today by someone who has been in deep coma for the last quarter of a century. I dare say that faith in the supernatural, angels, a six-thousand-year-old world fashioned in six days, and a human race descended from two parentless and naked people in a garden somewhere in ancient Mesopotamia who were tricked by a snake into eating a piece of forbidden fruit has never been as lively as it is today.

Spectral Hermeneutics

My own version of weak theology is the offspring of a spectral hermeneutics, of what I have been calling for some time now radical hermeneutics, as distinct from Vattimo's, in whom I do find, I repeat, a kindred spirit. If in my weak theology everything turns on the distinction between the name and event, the hesitations I feel about Vattimo center around how "strong" the names of Christianity and the Incarnation remain in his thought, where such strength comes at the cost of the event, whose most important effect is to weaken any such names. Accordingly, I wonder if Vattimo's weak thinking is too strong and if his version of radical hermeneutics, because it has not truly eradicated this strength, is not sufficiently hauntological—and radical.

When all is said and done, my hesitation about Vattimo is that there is no counterpart in his work to what Derrida calls *khora*. This is the figure that Derrida borrows from Plato's *Timaeus*, although it is also linked by Derrida to the figure of a desert, of an archi-desert within the biblical desert, to emblemize the elemental spacing in which all our natural languages and historical

institutions are inscribed. The effect of this figure in Derrida is to underline the sense of the contingency and deconstructibility—the weakness—of the names that are inscribed in this desert space and hence the deep and intractable secret in which our lives are inscribed. But *khora* is also used by Derrida affirmatively, as the quasi condition of the im/possibility of prayer, as a way to describe a scene of messianic hope in the coming of someone, of a Messiah whose figure I cannot describe and hence a scene of desert prayers and tears and of desert hospitality. Since Vattimo has no counterpart to *khora*, the figures of the Christian Incarnation and more generally of incarnation itself go unchecked. Christianity is made the privileged figure of love and hospitality, which are made out to be distinctively Christian notions, a gesture that corresponds quite directly to the idea of a final revelation in Tillich. For all of Tillich's talk of the symbolic character of our language about God, his theory—like Gadamer's and Vattimo's—is situated within a Hegelian view of history as the transcription, transmission, and translation of a more robust and holy Spirit. But, for me, events are inscribed in the weaker, more ghostly play of *différance*. Events are haunted by a paler ghost in a more hauntological hermeneutics.

In a similar way, Vattimo's hermeneutics is less a weak hermeneutics of prayers and tears for some coming figure whose lines I cannot make out and more a robust hermeneutics of the application, realization, and translation into the secular world of the already given and authoritative figure of the Christian Incarnation. In my notion of a weak theology such an authoritative figure is far too strong. In the end, Vattimo offers us a hermeneutics of "application" in the Gadamerian mode, where the hermeneutic task is a matter of the application of an authoritative figure or "classic." I am concerned that Vattimo's hermeneutics is another example of something I have worried about in the past: when hermeneutics is too closely aligned with Gadamer, it comes un-

der the spell of Hegel and of some version of the metaphysical siren song that history is the way the absolute works itself out.⁴² Does that not here take the form of the thesis that Christianity is a classic truth that needs an updated application in the postmodern or secularized order?

But should it not be the work of weak thinking to weaken the force of such metaphysical tendencies, including the metaphysical distinction between an inexhaustible classic and its current application? When weak thinking works its way into its own story, when it finds a big story in which to tell a tall tale about the passage from strong metaphysical thinking to weak, from an alienated God to an incarnate God here on earth, and from orthodox Christian dogma to the contemporary secularized truth of Christianity in the postmodern world, then weak thinking has grown a little too strong. It is guided by a too authoritative and particular figure of truth and it proceeds on the basis of too strong an idea of truth as a classic that must find its contemporary realization.

Is not a truly radical hermeneutics a little more lost in the desert, a little more *destinerrant*?

Is not a radical theology less a matter of asking how do I apply and translate this authoritative figure of the God of Christianity to the contemporary world and more a matter of asking what do I love when I love my God?—where the name of God is the name of the event that is transpiring in the name of God?

Is not a radical hermeneutics a voice of one crying in the desert, praying and weeping in the desert?

Is not a radically weak theology a theology of the desert?

II

A Prayer for Silence

Dialogue with Gianni Vattimo

To start things off, could you briefly explain how you see the philosophical significance of the death of God?

For myself, there are complementary meanings of the death of God. In terms of Nietzsche, the anthropological meaning to the death of God is most clear. It is the idea that mankind has killed God because they recognize he is no longer a necessity. God was born into human consciousness to provide some security against the dangers of natural life. In this sense Nietzsche is similar to Giambattista Vico, who describes the condition of primitive man as somebody who sought in everything and every natural event the work of a god. In many senses this is the same in Nietzsche. The origins of God, therefore, lie in the natural processes through which we pray to God in order to protect ourselves from natural forces. As such, this primitive state of consciousness must be deconstructed. In addition, because humanity started to believe in God, it also started to have rules. The rules organized a sort of rational society that became another source of our security in this world. Science and technology developed in this vein as well. And that is why at a certain point God was no longer a necessity. Nietzsche sometimes expresses this in these

terms. Humanity also discovered that God was a lie. And if God had ordered them not to lie, God therefore negates himself. The idea is that in a civilized condition we no longer need such an extreme assurance, such a guarantee of our security.

This is the literal interpretation of the death of God, which I studied mainly in Nietzsche's works and in Heidegger's essay of 1943, "The Word of Nietzsche: 'God is Dead,'" and his lectures on Nietzsche published in two volumes. But the other, nonliteral, interpretation seems to me to be more convincing and not so strongly Nietzschean. I would say it this way: the death of God about which Nietzsche speaks is the death of Christ on the cross. Why? Because it is exactly after Christianity, or the event of Christianity, that it becomes possible to no longer believe in the classical, rational gods of the Greeks.

There is an important idea from Dilthey, *Einfuehrung in die Geisteswissenschaften*, that says, above all, metaphysics was killed by Christianity because Christianity turned the attention of man inward so that philosophy became subjective, more Cartesian. This, by the way, is very important for Heidegger: remember that Heidegger in *Being and Time* said that what he wanted to do was simply make more understandable and clear to the people of his time the teachings of Dilthey. That is the case even though Heidegger himself never developed a specific commentary on Dilthey.

Of course, Dilthey also asked the question why metaphysics lasted so long given the fact that Christianity began two thousand years ago. There are complementary processes that Dilthey sees between the one and the other. At the end of the Roman Empire the bishops were almost the only authorities still in existence around the ancient world. For example, Augustine was both a philosopher and a bishop. On the one hand, as a philosopher he calls the people to come back to themselves by inhabit-

ing the mind within. On the other hand, as a bishop he had to organize a community, to take cover and protect the structures of the ancient world. This is more or less a popularized version of the idea from Dilthey—that is, the Church has the possibility to completely renew a community founded on the event of Christianity that puts an end to metaphysics. But they did not do that because they still were very strongly engaged in secular culture. So only after a lot of revolutions did Christianity realize that the core idea of Christianity was the negation of a necessarily objective rational (i.e., eternal) structure of the world. This takes time, of course, and it can occur only in a Protestant world. At any rate, the ethical Christianity under development involves the dissolution of the faith in the metaphysical structure of the world. This is historicism in many senses, which corresponds to the history of salvation and so on.

Now, when Nietzsche says that God is dead, as a matter of fact he is only developing this extreme point introduced to the world by Christianity of the historicity of history. In other words, no structure, no objective or eternal God, just as Christianity has always said. So I would say that this connection between my thought and Nietzsche and the idea of secularization, etc., is that Nietzsche realized the occurrence of the death of God that corresponds to the idea of the dissolution of metaphysics. We don't believe in the Greek metaphysical God as the rational structure of the world. This God obviously has nothing to do with the Christian God.

What is the connection between your idea of “weak thought” or the “weakening of being” with the theological image of the death of God?

I must confess that the theological movement of the death of God is not something I've studied intensely. While there are many important authors such as G. Vahanian, W. Hamilton, T.

Altizer, J. Robinson, H. Cox, and V. Buren who have escaped the natural intentions of traditional theology and who have successfully articulated a theology without God, they could never have done this work without Luther or Nietzsche, for example. Also, my use of the death of God depends very much on the history of Being as connected to the problem of ontotheology. In this more philosophical context, the theology of the death of God has a great deal of current resonance and force. It becomes part of a much larger effort that speaks not only of the death of God but also of the end of metaphysics and the end of truth. So, in answer to your question, I would say that my notion of weak thought can actually help the death of God theologies better understand their origins in Nietzsche's and Heidegger's philosophy and in the broader context of the end of metaphysics.

In After Christianity, you write that "the end of metaphysics and the death of the moral God have liquidated the philosophical basis of atheism."¹ Why is it, according to your understanding, that the death of God does not necessarily eventuate in atheism?

There is an Italian saying that I sometimes make reference to: "Thank God I'm an atheist." Of course, this is referring to the God of the philosophers. God can only be propped up or demonstrated by reason or rational argument for so long. Yet this effort to demonstrate the rationality of belief is still something the Catholic Church feels very strongly about. Why? Partly, it is a matter of remaining faithful to the medieval tradition. After all, it is only natural that the Church assumes that the real, true human culture was the period when the Church had the most power. So in many senses there is a sort of historical imprinting in the Church, like they would like to go back to the Middle Ages if they could. But there is also the matter of power. As long as the Church can depend on some natural, rational ethical structure, they can try to enforce this ethics not only on the

believers but on everybody. The examples in Italy are many. For instance, they have tried to keep the law against divorce in Italy. In addition, more recently, under the strong leadership of Cardinal Camillo Ruini, the pope's vicar in Rome and president of the Italian bishops' conference, and with the explicit support of Pope Benedict, the Church mobilized at all levels to persuade Italians to stay away from the ballot box, with the goal of keeping turnout lower than 50 percent and thereby invalidating the referendum on medically assisted procreation. They do this not on the basis that it is an aspect of Christian law but rather that it is an aspect of natural law. Now they are arguing the same thing with regard to various facets of bioethics.

This corresponds very well to my idea of metaphysics, which I define as the violent imposition of an order that is declared objective and natural and therefore cannot be violated and is no longer an object of discussion. By the way, this is also why we can believe that Heidegger was against metaphysics for exactly the same reason. If you admit there is a first principle that can be grasped and known in a definite way, you prevent anybody from ever asking again. So, on this basis, I have developed the following theory with regard to violence. As I have explained in *Nihilism and Emancipation*,² violence is the fact of shutting down, silencing, breaking off the dialogue of questions and answers. This is what ultimate foundations do; they impose themselves as impervious to further questions as objects of contemplation and *amor dei intellectualis*.

When I say that, it seems as though it is exaggerated. Why? Think about war, for example, as Pascal observed, if you kill someone on this side of the river, you are declared a hero, but on the other side you are an assassin. What about euthanasia? Once more, the reason the Church doesn't want to speak about this is because they believe there is an objective violence in killing. Yes, but what about God? If there is an objective violence

to killing somebody, then it would follow that God is the biggest murderer of all. Violence, then, is the fact of no longer permitting the other to ask questions. Now, the Church, on one side, pretends that they very much respect human nature, human reason, and things like that, but, on the other side, the very core of this is that they want to impose their view of the natural essence of man, reason, etc., which involves a certain authoritarian posture.

Building on this comment you made about violence being the fact of shutting down, silencing, or breaking off the dialogue, this violent imposition of power is quite apparent throughout the city of Rome. Being here in Rome, one cannot help but notice the contrast between the ruins of imperial Rome and the Church triumphant. This cityscape seems to me to be an apt visual for your idea about the dissolution of metaphysics.

Yes, we grew up with the idea that the magnificence of the Church continues without any interruption from the history of the Roman times. In many senses, this idea is more natural for us than for you Americans. But, of course, somebody might also wonder about the signs indicating that the Church is no longer so alive. Even when the Church insists on doctrinal conformity and engages in various inquisitions—this reveals a certain confessional weakness because it promotes in a conceptual way the idea of the Church as an army. An army regiments your sexual life, for instance, enforcing rigid conformity and discipline. In many senses, the insistence of the Catholic Church on these points is a way of training an army that is supposed to be ready for a new war, a new world. Otherwise it makes no sense to insist so much on their position on prophylactics. When I try to understand why Pope John Paul II was so strongly engaged in reproduction politics, I wonder whether he was afraid of social change, such as the reduction of the birthrate or the influx of immigration

of other religions. Does the Pope wish to increase the number of immigrants who are notoriously more prolific? It seems to me that the most reactionary part of the Catholic Church can count upon the development of the third world churches. These churches are much worse than ours from a theological view. For one, many are part of minority communities, so they are strongly communitarian, going back to primitive Christianity. They are also dogmatic; they believe in wonders, etc. If that is the case, then we secular Europeans are faced with some very difficult days ahead.

I want to talk about that a bit, specifically about the future of the Church, because your book with Jacques Derrida, On Religion, is credited by many with bringing the return of religion to the attention of philosophers. But when we talk about the return of religion—at least in your work—we are also talking about the process of secularization. So can you explain the connection between the return of religion, which is often violent and as you say in the third world often primitive, with the simultaneous process of secularization, which is associated with modernity and the West?

The connection has many meanings in my mind. In one sense, it is exactly because of the loss of a unified religious authority that there is a sort of rebirth of religiosity. Real religiosity relies on secularization because religion is no longer single or uniform and there is no longer a central religious authority. On the other hand, secularization and the new religiosity are also related by a sort of therapeutic connection because if I am ready to accept literally the return of religion in Italy, I would say that this religiosity tends again to be a sort of resecularized religiosity—that is, a religiosity that lives only as a consequence of secularization. For example, Pope John Paul II made great use of the media, his message was communicated via television, and, as his death

such things as democracy, secularization, modernization, and so on. You have written that modernity is “unthinkable” apart from the Christian heritage and, further, that the task of secularization is not only the message of the New Testament but also constitutes the very destiny of the West. Finally, you have said that it is not possible to have a non-Christian philosophy. My question is how this privileging of the Christian heritage does not lead us back to the very form of religious triumphalism you are trying to avoid.

Once again I would say that the problem of Christian triumphalism is based on a sort of literal reading of the Bible. I see modernity as a dissolution of the sacred distance between God and the world. So if I understand modernity in these terms, then I understand that I cannot think of modernity without this origin or basis in Christian incarnationism. But also, as I mentioned before, I can also make the confession “Thank God I’m an atheist.” Only because of the event of Christianity can we be modern and no longer believe in a sacrificial God, as René Girard has said, or in a literal God. This is the path described by Joachim of Fiore—who, by the way, I have a great difficulty understanding—when he speaks of the age of the spirit. My view of the future of religion and of Christianity is based exactly on his idea of the intense spiritualization of the Holy Scriptures, which means no longer taking even the primacy of the pope literally. This relativization or spiritualization of religious authority can be seen in the dispute that exists among biblical scholars about which is the first of the gospels. Most scholars say Mark, but the Church prefers to say it was Matthew because that is where the statement about Peter being the rock upon which Christ will build the Church is found. So it is a matter of what I prefer the Church to be.

Getting back to this question about the Christian meaning of secularization and Christianity having a meaning today only through secularization, it raises the critical issue about the role

of the Church in today's world. What do we do with the Church? My answer is that we have to invent another meaning of the teaching of the Church, one that does not rest on the Church's efforts at concentrating power in the Vatican. What I would say is that if the Church believes that it is best to go on concentrating its authority and insisting on certain literal readings of the Bible, how long can it last? This is not simply a hermeneutical or philosophical problem, it is practical as well. Take, for example, the question of women priests. We don't have many priests as it is, so if a woman wants to become a priest, then OK. Same with the issue of condoms, as we've already discussed. These are all things that John Cornwell explained very well in his book, *Breaking Faith: The Pope, the People, and the Fate of Catholicism*. Of course, this touches on the matter of the authority of the Church itself. If the Church still preaches something that appears to be lacking in credibility, that is utterly absent in meaning, then the only way would be for the Church to gradually ease its doctrine bit by bit. Imagine if I were pope and tomorrow announced that everything was permissible—obviously that would spell the Church's destruction. But, at the same time, in order to be preserved, the Church has to change.

Following your interpretation, then, couldn't one just as easily talk about the idea that there can be no philosophy without its Islamic transmission through the Middle Ages? Or, as your friend Umberto Eco writes in his wonderfully imaginative novels, he is always picking up these alternative strands within the historic tradition to somehow question or unbalance the dominant or prevailing tradition. My question is whether you might be caught in a contradiction, since it is not only that there can be no philosophy apart from Christianity, because, first of all, Christianity itself is not a single or uniform tradition and, second of all, regardless of how Christian is the character of the Western philosophical tradition, it might very well have been lost or forgotten without the benefit of Islam.

Changing directions a bit, I want to ask you about your impressions of faith and politics in the context of the United States. Two questions about this: First, to what extent do you see today's global political conflict driven by religious interests? I'm thinking here about what you would say about the notion of the so-called clash of civilizations, specifically, the role religion might play in this conflict. Second, much attention has been paid to President Bush's faith and the integral role the evangelical right played in his reelection campaign in 2004. My question here is to what extent do you think this apparent politicization of religion should be an item of concern or alarm.

For the first question, with this situation it becomes clearer and clearer that Marx was right about the ideological function of religion. The notion of the clash of civilizations was developed under the influence of general political ideology. It is true that even under Saddam Hussein there were clashes of religious groups within Iraq. Of course, this was aggravated by the fact that the West had created the conditions for the boundaries of the state. Iraq was a state in which people of different ethnic origins and religious traditions were put together only in order to create unstable conditions, thus necessitating the intervention of the West. But also, again paradoxically, the apparent clash of civilizations is powered by the proliferation of the media as we see when Al Qaeda uses Al Jazeera for communicating its message. There is a mixture between modern technology and real or pretended religious belongings.

Abdelwahab Meddeb wrote an insightful book on the relation between modern technology and religious fundamentalism, *The Malady of Islam*, in which he starts by explaining that if fanaticism was the sickness in Catholicism and Nazism was the sickness in Germany, then surely fundamentalism is the sickness in Islam. Meddeb believes that if the politicians who govern our world had intervened to save the Buddhas from the destruction of the colossi of Bamiyan on March 9, 2001 (the Taliban did announce

they were going to destroy them a few days earlier), New York would have escaped the loss of its twin towers: they are after all two acts of destructions that belong to one single tragedy. Through his erudite and historical analysis Meddeb shows how the rise of fundamentalism has its roots in European colonization and American neocolonial domination of the Islamic world. Until the baroque and classical periods, Islamic civilization kept pace with European cultures and their developments in science and art. This progress was suddenly disrupted because of the progressive loss of international commerce. Islam had established its greatness at the very moment when Europe had fallen into lethargy (from the eighth to the eleventh century). One of the effects of the Crusades—which lasted two centuries, from 1099 to 1270—was the reestablishment of the dynamism of the Italian city-states (Genoa, Pisa, Venice), which broke the Islamic monopoly on Mediterranean commerce. This is also why, for example, in the Middle Ages we had the Crusades. The Crusades were clearly preached in religious terms and encouraged by religious authorities, but they were also about the redistribution of power and the conquering of new markets. The Italian Middle Ages were developed precisely by these means. The primitive bourgeoisie were those who reaped the advantages from these expanded markets and travels.

So I would say beware of discounting a Marxian analysis too quickly. After all, concerning Bush's war in Iraq, Marx is absolutely right. It is just a matter of ideological masking. The logic is as follows—we are in this war first because we are believers. As believers, we want to expand democracy. If they will not accept our democracy, then we will bomb them. Then, at the end of the journey, there is, of course, oil. But, after all, Americans such as Noam Chomsky and Michael Moore have marvelously explained this dynamic, which has become increasingly apparent to everyone.

With that in mind, clearly there would be a great advantage to demythologizing the religious component in this struggle because many of the factors are not religious in nature but ideological. On the other hand, if there are some who still believe we are struggling in Iraq against the devil, this would be a way to educate them, to show them otherwise. It is like modernization; modernization is in many senses desacralizing. What Christianity should do in our world is to be a little more materialistic, to show that God is not involved in our struggles; rather, our struggles are about oil, domination, power, and so on.

It is also a matter of conversion. Only through conversion can people start to understand Marx. As a good Christian, I have to understand that God is not on my side in a war or somehow aligned with one side in the so-called clash of civilizations. This is exactly what a Marxist would say. If someone still believes that God is on his side in war, then he has to be demythologized. Even President Bush. But with Bush—does he believe or not? When I think that he truly believes, I imagine that his conversion was an absolute misfortune for the world. But then, this is not a question about Bush but a matter of a certain logic of the military-industrial complex instead.

Then, with regard to this second question about whether this politicization of religion should be of concern, you would say that it needs to be demythologized?

Philosophy has to be a modernity discourse, that is, a secularizing discourse. For instance, today, in France, when they say there is a struggle about the integration of Muslims into French culture, it is also a matter about the material conditions of life. This is obviously the case with many of our problems today. If a rich Saudi buys an apartment in my neighborhood, do I feel like I am in a clash of civilizations? No, because he is rich. The only thing is that it leads to an increased property value in my

This is my suspicion too. It is true that postmodernism involves this idea of mobility and hybridity—imagine the picture of a yuppie. But I am not sure that I could describe what the poor in this situation would actually desire. Negri, like many post-Marxist-Leninists, believes that he represents these people. But, after all, he is a yuppie. He knows personally all the members of the establishment. As a matter of fact, this is a mistake that many revolutionaries make. The mistake they make is that they always believe that they represent the people without a voice. It is like the Church pretending to represent the rights of the embryo.

But, to answer the question, I realize that the problem of postmodernism is a sort of a privileged position. But the university education in past centuries was a privileged position as well. This was not a reason to reject the efforts to provide a university education for everybody. Now it is possible that in the postmodern world this problem is compounded by its easing of communications, making populism more and more attractive as the ambiguous identification with the rich by the poor. After all, many poor people in Italy voted for Berlusconi. But, again, I have to ask the poor. If the poor voted for Berlusconi, how can I decide that I speak in their real interests? I do try to persuade them not to vote for Berlusconi, but surely not by saying that I know their real interests.

Finally, then, I would say that this is an indication of the ideological rigidity of Tony Negri. Regarding Hardt and Negri's entire project, I have the same objection Noam Chomsky had of it—namely, why did they need to say in a complicated way what you can say in an easier way? I have the feeling that not only do they not represent the so-called multitude but neither do they want to be understood by them if they make their book so complicated. This is an old game that intellectuals play to gain prestige and power. In contrast to this approach, Santiago Zabala and I are currently at work on a book on politics, to be

entitled *From Within*, in which we hope to show how socialism is what you get when one starts to criticize the inequalities of capitalism. In the meantime, I would recommend Richard Rorty's *Achieving Our Country: Leftist Thought in Twentieth-Century America* as the best instrument for progressives in America who are interested in changing the direction of their country. This is a book that can promote serious democratic initiatives instead of Negri's intellectual discussions on metaphysical essences such as "empire" or "multitude" that are quite useless for political activism.

As Zabala describes in his introduction to your philosophy in Weakening Philosophy, the origins of your concern with "weak ontology" and "weak thought" was your effort to speak to the new democratic left and your concern with how many young, radical, revolutionary Leninists on the left were still beholden to strong metaphysical assumptions. In this way your political philosophy has always been concerned with the connection between violence and metaphysics and, further, the permanent potential of terrorism. How, if at all, has your thinking on these matters changed or developed through the years?

Yes, what Zabala explained in the introduction is a very important factor in explaining the meaning and origin of weak thought. With my teacher, Luigi Pareyson, the most important philosopher since Croce in Italy, we were always telling each other that we were much more revolutionary than the student revolution of '68. That is because we were reading Heidegger, hence reading a philosopher who tried to overcome objective metaphysics, which so often gives rise to violence. Weak thought became not only a response to the violence of terrorism but also an unveiling—to the extent that I was even threatened by many of the revolutionaries. Of course, today the situation is a little different, but I do still believe that weak thought is the best response we can give to violence and discrimination.

In my conversation with John Caputo, he discusses the promise of a democracy to come. Caputo states that the promise of democracy is that it is self-correcting or auto-deconstructing. And, when talking about the democracy to come, he borrows from a comment first made by Derrida, in which Derrida stated, "Maybe in the expression 'the democracy to come' the 'to come' is more important than the 'democracy.'" One reason for this is that there are no "existing democracies" but only the "dream" of democracy. How would you respond to this statement that Caputo draws from Derrida? Specifically, do you think this futural, almost messianic tone is appropriate for political philosophy, and does it provide an adequate philosophical base for political activism?

This is a difficult question because I cannot understand why Caputo put more emphasis on the "to come" rather than "democracy." Perhaps it is because of his Heideggerian background, indicating the fact that he remains very much conditioned by him.

But there is also a sense in which I agree with the emphasis put on the "to come"—namely, the fact that democracy seem to me a permanent future more than a constitutional status. This is visible above all if we consider the existing democracies or so-called democracies. The frequently repeated question about whether or not democracy will prohibit antidemocratic parties—thus contradicting itself—shows that it can never be considered a given reality. It is always a program, a value. I feel in democracy an accent of Heideggerian "projectuality," and it seems to me that the current crisis of democratic societies depends on the fact that citizens don't accept this projectuality. We can never think that democracy is actual; hence the many implications for political participation. What Roberto Mangabeira Unger has called a "high potential democracy" looks far more similar to what had been planned to be the soviets—the popular councils that had to determine the political decisions (and existed only for a while at the beginning of the Russian revolution), than to

our formal electoral democracies (which are, by the way, full of corruption and strongly dependent on big money).

But, getting back to Derrida's expression, I think both expressions must be read together, and neither of the two should be emphasized more than the other because they could fall into metaphysics too easily. If we only talk about the future, then we may never accomplish what we want and, on the other hand, if we only describe how democracy should be, then we might forget that it is something constituted in such a way as to be modified through time. In *Nihilism and Emancipation* I give a complete account of what I understand by democracy in chapters 7 and 8.

Final question. Returning to Negri and Hardt, and adding Giorgio Agamben to the discussion, they have expressed grave concerns for the future of democracy. Hardt and Negri's Multitude begins with a critical analysis of the permanent state of war that has become a standard feature of the current international order as dominated by the United States. Similarly, Agamben has written extensively about the "state of exception" that threatens to transform democracies into totalitarian states. Speaking from your dual expertise as a philosopher combined with your experience as an actual politician as a former member of the European Parliament, do you agree that this state of exception has become the new working paradigm of government? If so, then what can be done?

If I believed that this had become the paradigm, then the simple answer to the last question would be that there is nothing that can be done. On the basis of my experience in the European Parliament, I feel very strongly that the logic of war is becoming the logic of everyday life. We speak more and more explicitly in war terms. It is also the game of power. For example, while I would not say that Bush provoked 9/11, surely he has exploited it very, very well, to the point that books such as *Before and*

replication of autonomous centers. I believe in that. After all, there is nothing better to believe in. Isn't this the very idea of the multitude? Having many communities working—not necessarily together in the sense of a coordinated effort—but simply working against.

That is why I sometimes call myself an anarchist. I have proposed in the conclusion to one of my recent papers that we take seriously the idea from a book by Reiner Schürmann on Heidegger (*On Being and Acting: From Principles to Anarchy*). Schürmann emphasized how Heidegger had preached the end of the epoch dominated by an *arché*, by the principle, so that we now live in an anarchic age. But now I would say we have to interpret this a little more literally. We have to be outside. This is a postmodern idea. The idea is that I must subtract myself from the game of power. For instance, it was important for me to no longer be elected as a member of parliament. I discovered I could do something without too many engagements vis-à-vis a party. I discovered that when you get into power, it is not because you have conquered the power, but because the power has conquered you.

My interest in mysticism was stimulated by my Catholic starting point. While the mystical tradition pervades the Christian Middle Ages, it acquires a certain ascendancy at the end, in the twilight of the great scholastic systems when philosophical rationality was beginning to decline. A certain skepticism emerges about metaphysics accompanied by a turn to the mystical. My interest in the mystical is rooted in the fact that it positions itself at the limits of metaphysical reason. One of the books that I cherished as an undergraduate was Jacques Maritain's *The Degrees of Knowledge*, which described a sort of ladder of ascent of the soul to God—from metaphysical reason, through faith, to mysticism. Maritain places mysticism at the peak, while faith itself remains still in the dark.

So I have always been addressing the question of the limits of philosophy by way of its exposure to religious discourse. In a certain way it has always been the same question, but in the first half of my work I tended to see the mystical, and also what Heidegger called thinking, as a kind of crowning perfection that superseded rationality. With Heidegger, the notion of the experience of thought is deeper than metaphysical reason, even as mystical union crowns what metaphysical theology seeks. But with my turn to Derrida—my real confrontation with Derrida began in the early 1980s—I began to see not so much a *crowning* but the *delimitation* of reason. At the same time, my sense of the religious became a lot less mystical and a lot more prophetic or ethicopolitical, and I became a little skeptical about the very idea of something “deeper.” In deconstruction the delimitation of rationality is not made in the name of something deeper, but in the name of something other or new or novel, of an event rather than an abyss of Being. The stress is not upon nonknowing in the classical mystical sense, where that implies an even deeper, “learned” nonknowing, but rather nonknowing in the sense that we really don't know! Nonknowing is not an expression of a deeper truth;

it means that we really don't know! So, in that sense, there's a genuine continuity in these books, but there is also a real turn, and the occasion of the turn is Derrida. I blame everything on Derrida. [*Laughter*] Whenever I get in trouble, I blame Derrida.

Would you say that your skepticism is now directed at both metaphysics and mysticism?

Yes, but not in such a way as to say there's something bogus about mysticism or that we can dismiss metaphysics. My skepticism has to do with the interpretations that are given to mystical experience, including those of the mystics themselves. Clearly mystical experience is important and life transforming, but like every experience—this is what we mean by hermeneutics—it requires interpretation. Something very important is happening, but the question is what. What kinds of words do we give to what's happening? And then, in that regard, I'm a bit skeptical. We must admit that these experiences could mean many things, including even certain pathological things. So, in my more orthodox Catholic youth, I would have said that in mystical experience we are touched by . . .

Revelation?

Yes, and even beyond revelation—by God, directly, immediately, wordlessly, whereas Revelation is always given in words. Whereas now I stress that we are touched by something I know not what.

We'll return to the subject of the death of God later, but could you equate this nonknowing, this radical turn in your own thought, as a moment of the death of God?

Yes. For the death of God certainly means the dying off not only of ontotheology and of classical metaphysical theology but also of this notion of a supervening mystical unity conceived as

the fulfillment or the crowning of metaphysical theology. The death of God entails the deconstruction not only of the *ousia* of classical metaphysics but also the *hyperousios* of Neoplatonic mysticism. The value of the notion of the death of God is that it gives a provocative name to an ancient and venerable tradition, the ongoing work of the critique of idols, one of which is certainly the idol of some naked prelinguistic ineffable given, which is pretty much what the *hyperousios* comes down to in classical mysticism. Mystics often claim to speak from within the heart of God, with a kind of absolute knowledge or absolute point of view. I value mysticism as an expression of our nonknowing, but my skepticism has to do with reaching this absolute point of view. One important thing we mean by the death of God is the death of the absolute center, of inhabiting an absolute point of view. That's the point of Derrida's critique of negative theology—which he calls hyperousiology—which is also why deconstruction is not negative theology.

In the face of this epistemological uncertainty, or in the wake of it, what then is the task or the point of philosophical and religious thought? What is its effect?

Well, on the one hand, serious philosophy and theology involve a work of ceaseless critique of our capacity to deceive ourselves. They remind us that everyone is on the same footing, that no one enjoys privileged access. This has a salutary ethical and political import because it shows us that we're all in this together and that nobody is hardwired up to the Secret. That produces a desirable ethical, political, and religious effect—an egalitarian effect.

But I think that philosophical and theological thinking have to be—beyond critique and uncertainty—affirmative. If all there is to thinking is critique and delimitation, skepticism and doubt, then it will not inspire us. It will simply be disruptive and negative. So I

think that philosophy is always looking for a way to articulate what we love, what we desire, what drives us. That is the Augustinian side of my work, which is emblemized by what Augustine calls at the beginning of the *Confessions* the *cor inquietum*—the restless heart. We write with both hands. Radical critique and delimitation is the left hand, but the right hand is the affirmation of something that we desire with a desire beyond desire, which is the sum and substance of my argument in *Prayers and Tears*, which conceives of praying and weeping in a deeply affirmative way. Something can be affirmative—we can say yes to it, for that is what we love—without being positive. That is to say, we may lack a positive formula for what we affirm. Whenever someone erects a positive content, making our affirmation into a determinate object, that can always be deconstructed. Whatever is constructed can be deconstructed, otherwise it is a menace or an idol. But the affirmation itself is irreducible. So I would say philosophy—philosophical and theological thinking, really any kind of thinking at all—has to be driven by a radically affirmative energy, by a desire for what is undeconstructible.

Could you give us an example of the difference between this affirmative energy and something that has a positive content? What exactly is the difference?

The positive can be located as soon as the affirmation is contracted to some ontical and historically constructed form. These forms are the inescapable materials and circumstance of our lives, the things that time and place have put at our disposal. They are the things we know, the historically determinate forms in which our desires take shape. For instance, the great monotheistic religions are all ways of giving determinate positive content to our desire for God, and even more fundamentally to our desire *tout court*. The great philosophical systems or constructions of Hegel and Kant and even Heidegger do the same thing. But in my view what they say, the positive programs of both the philosophers

and the theologians, must be regarded with a certain ironic distance. These are beautiful and powerful constructions, but they are, as such, deconstructible. They have positive and determinate content, having been constructed out of historical, social, political materials. But they're deconstructible. Whatever has been constructed, whatever exists, whatever is present, is deconstructible. What we affirm is the event these programs contain, which is not deconstructible. That doesn't mean that one thing is as good as another.

It seems to me that the nonknowing, the skepticism, and the irony would have a debilitating effect on anyone's affirmations or desires. Anything that I affirm is also deconstructible. Are my desires also in a sense deconstructible? I wonder what there is besides that which is deconstructible, and what to do about the potentially debilitating aspect of deconstruction?

That is why I distinguish between the construction and the event that the construction contains. I think that there is something irrepressible and irreducible, an event that is undeconstructible, a promise that animates these various deconstructible structures. Things start with the event of a promise. What we love and what we desire is the promise, what is promised. But this is also frustrating because promises are never completely delivered on and we are always being sold short. Still, we're driven or energized by something that stirs within these contingent objects of desire. Of course, you're right. I do think that the endless deconstructibility of the things we love poses a challenge. It is discouraging. But then having courage is precisely what's required in the face of what's discouraging. After all, that's what courage is.

I agree about what you say about our desires and what we love—that there's a sense in which we never get there. I understand how desire is always defeated, or always deferred, and that we never get there. But,

The link between *democracy* and the promise is that democracy is self-correcting or, as he says, “auto-deconstructing.” A democracy allows for its own revision or deconstruction, its own repeatability and revisability. It builds the future into itself so that—this is the hope—it doesn’t freeze over. It doesn’t take itself to be the last word. Therefore, the primacy of democracy will be that it is the most promising, however badly flawed. Today democracy has become just another name for capitalism. Sometimes it’s just another name for imperialism or consumerism. It’s a name for everything—all the evils you can think of get practiced under democracy. But that doesn’t mean that democracy is nothing. That doesn’t mean that democracy is not to be preferred to its alternative, which means that it shelters the promise in a way that the alternatives do not.

That also raises the question of Heidegger. One of the things that happened in the 1980s, when I really encountered Derrida, was that I reached my limit with Heidegger and I found it necessary, as Levinas put it, to leave the climate of his philosophy. Long after the war, in the *Der Spiegel* interview he gave in 1966, Heidegger was still saying that Stalinism and fascism and democracy were all “essentially the same.” I reached a point where I could not stand this “essential thinking” anymore. When it comes to politics, essential thinking is essentially stupidity. There are important differences among these structures, and if essential thinking has reached a philosophical point of view that erases those differences then so much the worse for what he calls thinking, which seems to me quite thoughtless.

But how then does Derrida or Derridean deconstruction account for its preference for democracy?

This comes back to this idea of autodeconstructibility. Democracy is a system that provides for its own correction. It proceeds from the idea that we have always to do with contingent

structures, revisable unities of meaning that are essentially deconstructible. At the same time, it's driven by an aspiration. It's not merely a system of self-criticism. It's driven by an aspiration for invention and plurivocity, for diversity and difference, for singularity. Were a democracy to come—and it cannot come, that would not be possible for it to actually come—it would not be a place in which there is pure harmony or perfect “peace.” It would be a place in which there would be endless and irreconcilable differences, a profusion of differences that would be adjudicated without killing one another. I do not think that in deconstruction democracy means moving in unison or harmony; it's a notion aimed at maximizing difference and endless reinvention. The dream of democracy—let's say it's prayer—is the dream of a world in which we would endlessly be able to reinvent ourselves, in which there would be a profusion of difference rather than fusion or playing in harmony.

Well, we can see that that world will never come.

The very nature of living, of being alive in time and history, means that what we affirm, what we desire, will never come.

But is the point to try to make the world that we do live in as much like that world as we can?

Yes, the point would be to make the impossible possible. My only proviso in saying this is that, in a theory as radically anti-essentialist as this, we should not think in terms of an ideal essence that we are trying to reach asymptotically. The promise is radically unforeseeable. The religious expression of this sentiment is to say that I do not know what I love when I love my God. So this word *democracy* is a placeholder, a stand-in, an antecedent state for something unforeseeable. We call it democracy, but I don't know what lies ahead or what it will be like. Furthermore, it might turn into a monster. It might become a disaster.

It might be awful. It might be worse than what we've got now. Every promise is also a threat. Once Derrida was asked, "If you talk about the democracy to come as unforeseeable, how do you know it'll be called democracy?" He answered that in the expression "the democracy to come" the "to come" is more important than the "democracy." I think that's right. It's the "to come," which is the structure of hope and expectation, that is the very nature of the promise that requires faith and love and hope. This is why I think the whole thing has a religious dimension. Deconstruction is structured like a religion, but not of the orthodox, classical variety.

I can imagine critics saying that this all sounds very ephemeral.

Well, in an important sense that would be true. The democracy to come is a specter. It has a ghostly, spectral "hauntological" dimension that keeps us up at night. I agree with you that we're dreaming now, dreaming out loud, but I think that dreaming is important, that it is essential. Still, during the waking day, these dreams would have to be linked to most detailed analyses of concrete institutions and structures. And that's why when people dream their dreams should always be accompanied by very careful, close, and rigorous analyses. We need trained political and legal theorists who understand political structures and economics and the law and who can do concrete scientific work, but who are inspired by this dream, by this kind of understanding. I am thinking of theorists like Drucilla Cornell, who has put the dreams of Derrida to work in a concrete way in radical legal theory, or Ernesto Laclau and Chantal Mouffe, in political theory, or Peter Eisenmann, in architecture, and the list goes on. These people do real work that is acknowledged by their peers. They meet the protocols of their discipline. But they also dream these kinds of dreams. So it is true. What we're doing—what I'm doing—is a dream. But the dream is important. What I and

many others have been trying to do is to bring these dreams to bear upon theological and religious analyses, to find a way to talk about the Church and theology and God. It impacts upon religion and architecture, in principle upon everything—deconstruction is not a body of doctrines but a way to think and question—but it impacts upon them all as a dream of something to come.

The idea of the democracy to come is especially interesting in light of the thinking and work of Gianni Vattimo. As you know, Vattimo has not only written a great deal about political philosophy but also, at least for time, he was an actual politician serving in the European Parliament. He has been critical of various currents in contemporary political philosophy because of either its ideological rigidity or its impracticality. In this way he has aligned himself with the neo-pragmatism of someone like Richard Rorty. How does your understanding of democracy to come and this Derridian imperative to dream compare?

I am very sympathetic with Rorty and Vattimo. Like them, I too have lost my patience with high political theory and I too look for more determinate ways to effect the democracy to come. Take the case of Badiou and Žižek. They complain about our inability to imagine anything other than capitalism, but there is no better example of this inability than these two noneconomists, Badiou and Žižek themselves, who do not offer the least realistic advice as to how to generate wealth differently, even as the whole world, including even China in its own way, has begun to adopt a market economy. They have abandoned a good deal of classical Marxism but they offer no real economic alternative to capitalism. As for myself, I would be perfectly happy if the far left politicians in the United States were able to reform the system by providing universal health care, effectively redistributing wealth more equitably with a revised IRS code, effectively restricting campaign financing, enfranchising all voters, treating

migrant workers humanely, and effecting a multilateral foreign policy that would integrate American power within the international community, etc., i.e., intervene upon capitalism by means of serious and far-reaching reforms. And to do that piecemeal over twenty-five years, the way the right wing has managed to do exactly the opposite. If after doing all that Badiou and Žižek complained that some Monster called Capitalism still stalks us, I would be inclined to greet that Monster with a yawn. Their idea of a “revolution” seems to me vacuous. I think deconstruction is implemented in a series of specific interventions, in concrete circumstances, and I think that is quite consonant with what Rorty calls neo-pragmatism and with Vattimo’s hermeneutics. My biggest and quite Derridean reservation regarding Rorty and Vattimo is a certain innocence in the way they put all this, which leads to a latent, or not so latent, chauvinism. Rorty is too inclined to call this program of intervention “achieving our country,” by which he means realizing the ideals of the United States, which for me does not put enough distance between the existing democracy we have here and the democracy to come. Vattimo is too inclined to say that this all comes down to achieving our religion, that is, transcribing or realizing “Christianity,” which is the West, which does not put enough distance between one of the concrete messianisms and the pure messianic hope. I think they both need a larger measure of the hermeneutics of suspicion, to put more distance between themselves and the United States or Christianity, to stay more on their toes about what Levinas and Derrida call the *tout autre*.

I want to stay with the political dimension of deconstruction for a minute. You once wrote of your solemn duty to “dispel the idea that Derrida is not an anarchist, a relativist, or a nihilist.” It strikes me this is perhaps the greatest accomplishment of your Prayers and Tears—that is, the compelling case you made that Derridean deconstruction is driven

by an affirmative, even a religious, passion, and thus proving, once and for all, that Derrida is not a “nut.” Once again, these are your words, not mine.

Did I say “nut”? [*Laughter*]

Yes. However, as you yourself confess, in making deconstruction look respectable, there is always the danger of domestication, of making Derrida and deconstruction safe. How have you negotiated between these twin dangers of, on the one hand, what you call the “axiomat-ics of indignation” in which critics automatically project onto Derrida their worst fears and, on the other, what we might call the “axiomat-ics of piety” in which religious advocates of Derrida project onto him their most treasured and heartfelt pieties? Or, more simply, how do you speak of the affirmative nature of deconstruction without stripping it of its critical edge?

Well, after just speaking of the need for a hermeneutics of suspicion, that’s a good question, especially for me, because I am more exposed to this second danger of making it “good,” of becoming pious. I don’t want to make deconstruction good or pious or to domesticate deconstruction. If it turns out to be good, then that would be awful. I need, we all need critics, people who get after me and keep me on my toes about the words that I love, like *love*. So, for example, as you well know, Gregg Lambert has lambasted me, as I said, about using the word *love*, which is a very pious word.¹ It is perhaps the most venerable and sentimental word in our vocabulary. And so it is very dangerous to talk about love and to describe deconstruction as love. Derrida talks like this himself, but that does not make it safe. So, when I am attacked like that, I regard that as being kept on guard about what I do. That is the danger that menaces what I do. Everything is dangerous, but this risk is what Levinas calls a beautiful risk; it’s a danger that is worth risking, because it is an even bigger risk to avoid love. After I wrote the response to Gregg, I

came upon a sentence of Lacan's cited by Žižek, "les non-dupes errent," those who are too smart to be duped by love outsmart themselves; those who do not want to be led astray by love are led astray. Love believes all things, but love is not deceived, which is the line from Saint Paul that Kierkegaard elaborates in *Works of Love*. That is why Derrida thought that deconstruction cannot proceed without love. So we must do exactly what you say, "negotiate" between these "twin dangers."

It also helps to consider the sort of religion—the "good" dimension—I am identifying in deconstruction. This religion is a nightmare to orthodoxy, which is very unhappy with it. That is something I experience fairly often. For some reason or another, I get invited to Christian colleges with evangelical cultures to talk about deconstruction and religion. I don't know why they do this. There are other people who are a little more up for that sort of thing than I am, but they invite me. And so I often get into a situation where I'm talking about the radical deconstructibility, the historical relativity, of Christianity, and then I get attacked and people say that this is destructive, this is awful, this is terrifying, this is a monster. Once a young woman looked me straight in the eye and said that I had been sent to her campus by the devil to test her faith. And that's good! Because then I'm being bad, and that's what I'm supposed to be. [*Laughter*] Deconstruction should be bad in order to avoid this danger you point out.

Is it important to you that deconstruction be either good or bad?

Not if that means everything is either black or white. But it is important to keep the tension alive between affirmation and critique, the possible and the impossible. I am always saying that, no matter how much it is critique, deconstruction is affirmation, that is, describing the difficult, even the impossible, conditions under which affirmation is made. In that sense it must be always be "bad,"

perhaps like the Michael Jackson song “Bad.” In order to avoid piety it must be scary and unnerving, and that would be good, because my constant claim is that we get the best results from facing up to the worst. In *Radical Hermeneutics* I said that by the title of this book I meant restoring life to its genuine difficulty and disarming the illusions we are always constructing. Describing in an honest way, insofar as we can be honest—if we could really be honest and explain or admit to ourselves the utter contingency and deconstructibility of the things we believe—that would be the beginning. If we could admit how bad things are, that would be the beginning of something good, of a kind of radical honesty with ourselves. That would inspire a certain compassion for one another because we would understand that we’re all in the same boat, all shipwrecked. To confess the wounded, fractured condition of our lives—that is who we are! And that would be the beginning of wisdom in deconstruction, of something good. If everyone actually believed that, if everybody acted on that, there would be better political processes and better relationships. If people actually believed that they really don’t know in some deep way what is true, we would have more modest and tolerant and humane institutions.

We could say that about anything. If everyone actually believed Karl Marx, the world would be a simpler place. If everyone were an evangelical Christian, the world would be a simpler place. But everyone’s not going to believe the same thing.

Yes, that would be simpler, but in that case simplicity would mean uniformity.

Yeah, well, we’d believe the same things, right?

What I want everyone to believe is that there is no one thing for everyone to believe. I want everyone to acknowledge the deeply contingent and historicized character of what they believe. Then, instead of everybody believing the same thing,

everybody would affirm the same right to be different. I mean something like Deleuze's univocity of being: what all things have in common is the singularity of their difference. There would be a flowering of differences, and we would all recognize that we don't know the Secret, what's true in some deep sense.

Of course, many are skeptical of such a position. There are people like Derrida—people like you—who can live comfortably with that kind of contingency. But, for a lot of people, that kind of radical contingency would be not only deeply frightening, but it might also approach what we might describe as a kind of psychosis. And I can imagine that one description of this psychosis would be schizophrenia. This sudden experience of radical contingency when everything becomes unfastened and nothing is predictable or secure.

So now we are back to negotiating between piety and scepticism. Without recommending pathological suffering and endorsing mental illness, I think that what Heidegger and Kierkegaard said about “being ready for anxiety” (*Angstbereit*) is right and liberating.

I mean, I think that's partly why your evangelical audiences respond as they do to you and to Derrida. Because they do understand what we're saying and it scares them.

I think that part of genuine mental health is to recognize a certain phenomenological psychosis, a certain nonpathological madness or instability. I often find myself struck by people who are able to live stably inside of a single worldview from beginning to end—from birth to death—and it's never broken. Maybe they've really questioned it and they've held on to it and not lost it. And then we eulogize them and we say that they're good and faithful servants. And I think, “that would be good!” I can admire that, but, as an intellectual, I cannot identify with it, and, at least for me, it represents a closed frame of mind.

The deconstruction you're speaking of . . . are you saying it's not a choice?
What do you mean?

You didn't choose to question your worldview. You didn't choose to grow uncomfortable in your given tradition. It's something that happened to you.

We make choices that get ourselves into this situation. Choosing to be an intellectual means that you set a course in a certain direction that is going to be risky and dangerous. You set a course that will make things questionable and it would have been more comfortable simply not to worry about those things. But intellectuals worry about everything; that's their business. They trouble themselves about presuppositions. Especially us. Especially people who are working in philosophy and religion. And there is a certain loss and there is something unnerving about it. But I think that then there's a kind of second level of joy or affirmation in which you recognize what you affirm and love, which is not finally reducible to these determinate finite structures. What I affirm survives the death of any given construction and has a more radical irreducibility.

But I agree that one can launch an intellectual career and hold on to a determinate, inherited faith. That happens all the time. Intellectuals are committed to Christianity, albeit in a more sophisticated way than the people in the pews are committed to it. I admire that, even if I am not quite there. On this point I follow Saint Paul: If God is God, God is not partial. And if God is not partial, there can't be any advantage to having been born a Christian that God would give to Christians and that God would withhold from others born in another time and place outside the reach of Christianity. The problem of religious pluralism is constantly getting radically honest theologians into trouble with the powers that be. Roger Haight is a good example in the Catholic tradition. There is something profound and important about the

I do not think Derrida is just a new spell! On the contrary, I began to write in my own name in a way that I had never done before. Like the Bible-thumpers, I can name the hour when I was born again: it happened in 1984 (a fateful date!), when I was writing the last three chapters of *Radical Hermeneutics*. That is when I found my voice. I kept staring at the manuscript, realizing that the book was not over, that something was missing, when I realized that what was missing was what *I* wanted to say, and those three chapters sketched the course of all my subsequent writings. I have been writing and rewriting those three chapters ever since. They prefigure *Against Ethics* and then, well, really everything, but especially *Prayers and Tears*, which really is “a game of Jacks.” Even I don’t know who is who in that book. Perhaps I should say that I am inspired by Derrida, but I go where he does not go. He’s not interested in religion in the same way that I am. We’re really very different people. He’s an Algerian Jew; I am the American grandchild of Italian Catholic immigrants. He rightly passes as an atheist; I rightly pass as a Christian. He was a world-famous intellectual, I am—well, enough of this.

I feel I instinctively know what he’s getting at when I read him—that I have the same kind of impulse. But I deploy my impulses on different materials. He thinks of me as a theologian. In this book that Mark Dooley edited where Mark interviewed Derrida about *Prayers and Tears*, throughout the interview, every time he referred to me, he referred to me as an American theologian. So I go in a direction that he doesn’t go and I pursue questions about Christianity that he doesn’t pursue and I am more deeply implicated in the “concrete messianism” that is Christianity.

One other difference between me and him is that I don’t put the same stock that he does in psychoanalysis. When I apply deconstruction to psychoanalysis, it just comes out as one more big story. I think that the idea of the unconscious is a crucial critical

Kierkegaard of the aesthetic literature is the model for the way that I write—which is, again, another difference between me and Derrida. Derrida is a subtle, elusive, playful, and avant-garde writer. I'm a playful writer, but not like Derrida, who is very difficult to read. I've been reading Derrida for years, but whenever I get a new text from him I always have to work through it slowly. It's always difficult. I don't write like that. I don't even try. The person who inspires me as a writer is the Kierkegaard of the pseudonymous literature. But what Kierkegaard and Derrida have in common—and what I find in both of them—is this: Kierkegaard has this deep, grave, serious, churchyard sensibility—his name means churchyard, graveyard—that is expressed in a brilliant humor. Derrida has this too, but Kierkegaard is a more accessible stylist. Kierkegaard is also the most consistent influence on me. From the time I was eighteen years old, when I first discovered him, Kierkegaard has been my hero. Unbroken. All the time I was studying Saint Thomas and, later on, Heidegger and then Derrida—at no matter what point in my life—Kierkegaard has always been my hero as a writer. What I try to cultivate, what I have learned from both Derrida and Kierkegaard, is this power of laughing through your tears, which distinguishes both from Heidegger. As Johannes Climacus says, humor serves as the incognito of the religious.

Has Derrida changed the way that you read or think about Kierkegaard?

Yes. I have consciously run them together. I will sometimes quip about something I call Danish deconstruction. I write in a space marked off by the proximity or congeniality of deconstruction and Kierkegaard. They are neighbors, siblings of a certain sort, although Kierkegaard is a Christian and religious in a way that Derrida is not. But it was Kierkegaard who helped me understand Derrida. Once, when we were together in a conference in Italy that I used to go to in the eighties, Derrida was there

lecturing on undecidability. That was when I first heard him say that undecidability is not the opposite of a decision, it is the condition of possibility of a decision. When I said to him, “That’s *Fear and Trembling*!” Derrida said, “Of course it is!” And that was where *Against Ethics* came from. I decided then and there to present a Derridean reconstruction of *Fear and Trembling* (just as *Radical Hermeneutics* was a kind of reconstruction of *Repetition*!). Then a funny but frightening thing happened. At the same time that *Against Ethics* appeared, Derrida published *Donner la mort*, which, of course, I would not have had a chance to read. So I read Derrida’s book with a little fear and trembling that my prediction of a Derridean reading of *Fear and Trembling* would be contradicted by its actual appearance! But I think it was not. Derrida is always saying how difficult it is to make a decision, how undecidable the situation is, how you can never economize on anxiety when you make a decision, and that is what a real decision is. From a certain point of view, that’s what deconstruction is, what it’s about. Derrida will emphasize the mirror play of complications that beset a decision, but Derrida is telling you what *Fear and Trembling* tells you, that at a certain point deliberation must cease and you must decide.

Then I saw clearly what a bad take it was on deconstruction to view it as aestheticism, as antireligious or ethically irresponsible. Decidability means that there’s a formal decision procedure for a decision, that a course of action or a decision can be formally derived, that it’s formally decidable, programmable. But what interests Derrida is situations that are formally undecidable, which is what Kierkegaard is all about, too. That is also what interested Aristotle, who was the first one to really see that making ethical choices, which requires *phronesis*, is not formalizable.

Some of Derrida’s more recent critics have linked this notion of undecidability with the political philosopher Carl Schmitt.

struction. I see that prophetic stream in connection with the Augustine of the *Confessions*, so that all of this flows together in the—for me—paradigmatic figure of the man of “prayers and tears,” which means the desire for God, and the question of what I love when I love my God. In this sense Christianity too is a Jewish science or Jewish practice. I see deconstruction touching a nerve—a messianic-prophetic nerve—that runs from the prophets through Jesus to a prophetic Christianity.

Of course, as we said earlier on, we must avoid heaping up too much piety and making things too simple. When I say “the prophetic,” as a kind of shorthand, I tend to condense into one everything that’s good and just and true, Martin Luther King and Dietrich Bonhoeffer, without making note of how much violence and hierarchy there is even in the prophets. I say somewhere Amos said he wants a religion without religion, but that’s not quite true. He just wants religion to clean up its act. So, I must avoid a certain tendency to present a kind of distilled, simplified picture of the prophetic and then call that Judaism and then call deconstruction Jewish and then present Christianity as extending this pristine virtue. Religion is much more violent and complicated than that.

But I would always be engaged in some kind of reinvention of biblical religion in dialogue with deconstruction. That’s what I do for a living. Philosophers annoy me when they try to insulate themselves against the biblical tradition, when they are dismissive and even contemptuous of it. Even when continental philosophers speak in the name of exposing philosophy to its “other”—by the other they usually mean literature or psychoanalysis! They don’t mean the Scriptures (or the natural sciences), even if you tell them that the Scriptures are literature! They don’t mean that. So I want to make philosophy vulnerable to religion and I want to expose religion to the resources of philosophical critique, to occupy the space between them. At

tion. But it also seems to me that it requires enormous boldness or audacity to say that you do theology, that you have something to say about God. That has been my attitude until recently. But then, in *The Weakness of God*, I decided to cave in—or to come out of the closet. I decided maybe I could get away with calling myself a theologian if I put it not in the form of an audacious claim but in the form of a confession. “Comment ne pas parler?” I cannot not talk about God. I cannot talk about anything else. No matter where I start, I always end up at God in some way or another. And since that is really what the word—*theology*—means, then I confess, I own up to this. I do not write about the history of religion but about God. I am—*je suis*, I am, I follow—a philosophical theologian who is feeling about for the event that stirs within biblical religion, and especially within Christian religion, seeking what is unconditional in the conditional and historical actuality of Christianity.

The meaning of postmodernism is to weaken the classical difference between theology and philosophy. The distinction between faith and reason, for example, does not finally hold up for me. I take reason to be deeply structured by faith and I take any faith that is not simply madness to be obliged to be articulate about itself and, so, rational in that sense. Virtually all of contemporary philosophy is bent on showing the way in which to understand something is to operate within a horizon of understanding that has to remain tentatively in place for you to get anything done. That horizon of understanding is something like a faith. It’s a presuppositional structure that is constantly getting tested, but it has to be in place.

By the same token, the natural/supernatural distinction also comes apart. To distinguish a natural order into which is injected some supernatural influx, some supernatural empowerment of our natural faculties, is, I think, to believe in magic. It’s a good thing I retired from Villanova just as I was getting so heretical!

for Badiou, Agamben, and Žižek, all this must be a surprise to that movement. It means that the distinctive notion of God and of God talk remains lively and important and has reasserted itself. It makes little sense to describe Derrida's *Circumfession* in terms of the death of God. When Derrida filled that ballroom in Toronto at the 2002 A.A.R. with some fifteen hundred to two thousand people, these were not people who came to hear about the death of God. The "desire for God" would be much better. Of course, our discourse about God is a historically contingent language, and—who knows?—maybe one day we won't have this language anymore. Maybe the language will transform itself into something else. But at this moment after the death of God, it seems apparent that God is making a comeback. The name of God is not dead but the language of God is very haunting, and Derrida in particular has responded to it. I don't think that we're done with it yet. I don't think that the name of God will leave us alone—not for a while. We do not know how not to talk about God. I think that God is taunting us, haunting us. It's a "hauntology," but not a matter for morticians.

I am struck by the fact that theologians have something going for them that the philosophers do not—here perhaps is a way to distinguish them! When philosophers try to name the so-called matter of ultimate concern, or the thing that is the most deeply resonant for them, they have recourse to an invented vocabulary. They'll speak of *being* or *substance* or *monad* or employ some such construct. They erect a technical vocabulary. They produce a term of art. But theologians draw upon a word that is deeply imbedded in our conscious and unconscious life, in our everyday life and in our most sublime moments, at birth and death and everything in between. The philosophers have nothing to compete with this. The name of *God* is a name that we learn at our mothers' breast, a word that's deeply embedded in our language, something that comes out in Levinas's analysis of *adieu*. It's a

word that saturates our experience and, for me, for deconstruction, I think it is endlessly, open-endedly analyzable. This is the event within it that invites us, waits for us, as Deleuze says. We seem never to get to the end of this word, never to finish probing this word and its work on us, what it's done to us. In that sense, this word contains a deeper provocation than anything else, and what it means always lies before us. That, I think, is what I don't like about the notion of the death of God. Apart from the fact that it's proven to be a sort of bad prediction, the discursive structure of the idea is to treat the name of God as something that we are putting behind us. The language is too decisive, as if henceforth this word is to be shut down and safely repackaged in some accessible, mundane form. It sounds like Hegel saying that art is a form that the Absolute has put behind itself. For me, the name of God is up ahead, the name of a provocation or solicitation, and it is undecidable.

This makes sense because, for many, the phrases "death of God," "secular theology," or "religion without religion" seem nonsensical almost, until you start to read the texts that they emerged from.

Yes. I think there is something intrinsically misleading about the language of the death of God that is cleared up when you study it. But it not only has a misleading rhetoric of death, more important, I think it follows a wrongheaded logic of transcription or transfer. To avoid misunderstanding it, to save the expression, it must always be reinscribed within a more affirmative context. I do not think the expression *religion without religion* is as misleading, but it too must be understood as an affirmation of something that is open-ended, ongoing, and futural, even if under a certain erasure. Religion passes through a kind of crucible of critique and delimitation—and this phase of critique one could certainly associate with the death of God—but it comes out the other end. Discursively, rhetorically, logically, the notion of the

death of God suggests a finality and mortality that is too simple, too decisive. In the 1960s Derrida said, “I do not believe in the simple death of anything.” He was talking in that context about the death of the book. For him, the dead have a specific way of living on. And then, of course, *Specters of Marx* is a hauntology, the logic of the specters that haunt us—not only Marx himself, but justice and the democracy to come, which are neither alive nor dead, neither being nor nonbeing. So, it’s just when we say that something is dead that it is not dead, that it is continuing to haunt us. In the end, for me, I speak of the death of God in a restricted sense, in the sense of a critique of ontotheology, of the God of metaphysics, and, in particular, the God of sovereignty and power and omnipotence. But then I move on because for me to speak of the death of God in any final sense would be to speak of “the death of desire” or “the death of love” or “the death of affirmation.” Now, of course, we must always and endlessly criticize the idols of ontotheology, endlessly practice a certain death of God, but always as part of a pact with a more open-ended project. In this regard, Anselm’s description of God as that than which there is nothing greater is helpful here because this is an interestingly “autodeconstructive” notion: whatever it is that you say that God is, God is more. The very constitution of the idea is to deconstitute any such constitution. And that’s built right into the idea. The very formula that describes God is that there is no formula with which God can be described.

I will always practice a certain strategic death of God theology, the death of some determinant idol, above all that of power. God should be undergoing a continual death in that sense. But it seems to me more productive and fruitful to think of God as the object of affirmation and desire. Then the question is not whether there is a God—no more than there is a question about whether there is desire—but the question is the one that Derrida picks out of Augustine’s *Confessions*: “What do I love when I love

my God?” God is the name—an endlessly translatable name—of what we love and desire and of affirmation and for me the question is, what is that? What do I desire? So the “death of God” is not a notion for which I have found much use. Of course, the name of God is historical, contingent, and it may be that for the love of God, and in the name of what we desire, we will have to give up this name. I have no inside information to pass on about that. It may be that this name will wither and give way to something completely unforeseeable. That would mean that a certain death of God can be accommodated by what I am calling the affirmation of this name. For, in the end, it is not the name of God that we affirm, but something—some “event”—that is being affirmed *in* our affirmation of the name of God.

You say that you do not have much use for the talk about the death of God. The idea of the death of God, however, still seems to play a central role in the philosophy of Gianni Vattimo. I wonder if his nuanced use of the talk of the death of God might be more acceptable to your understanding. For instance, in After Christianity, instead of simply saying that God is dead, he uses the alternative phrase, “the God who is dead.” In his book with Richard Rorty called The Future of Religion, he ironically repeats the saying, “Thank God I’m an atheist.” And in our discussion with him for the present volume he discusses the important relation between weak ontology and the death of God when he says that there are “no longer any strong reasons for being an atheist.” How do you interpret the significance of these various phrases from Vattimo, both for understanding Vattimo and in relation to your own work?

I have a great deal of use for Vattimo and an inner sympathy with what you are describing. He is one of the heroes of the current recovery of religious discourse. I take Vattimo’s project to be quite similar to mine: to radicalize the hermeneutic adventure, to push it to its extreme, and to do so in dialogue with Christianity. I also have great admiration for the thematic

according to which an inherited tradition like Christianity is more pitilessly historicized. Like all death of God schemata, it sees history through a rearview mirror; it looks back to the God who has come down to earth and is now transcribed into the pages of history. The name of God is the name of something that is behind us, and history is the process by which something that is behind us is now transcribed, applied, and transferred into time. The future is to become what we already are: a kind of realization or application, not a radical movement forward, a recollection, not a repetition forward. On my schema, which is a schema of desire and affirmation of the event that is harbored in the name of God, God is in front of us as the name of something that we desire with a desire behind desire, the name of an absolutely open-ended future, of an “event” that simmers as a certain “perhaps.” Let me be clear. I do accept the critique of idolatry, above all the critique of sovereignty and omnipotence, implied by the idea of the “death of God.” I accept its critique of two worlds, what Altizer calls the Gnosticism that has managed to cling to two thousand years of Christianity, and I too go back to Tillich in this regard. But I reject the periodization implicit in this schema (it has turned out to be a terrible sociological prediction, at least here in the United States). I reject the privileging of Christianity in which it is implicated. And I reject the way it puts the idea of God behind us. For me, the name of God is the name of an open-ended and unforeseeable future. For me, the work of theology is not a matter of transcription and application but a matter of prayers and tears, praying and weeping over what is to come.

Shifting directions a bit, I wanted to give you some opportunity to reflect on the political dimensions and the present global crisis we’re facing in the world today and how your ideas about religion without religion relate to things like fundamentalism and terrorism. In your book, On Religion, while explaining your notion of a religion without

go away. That is the importance of thinkers like Wittgenstein, Heidegger, and Derrida, all of whom have important things to say about what is going on in language and hence in religious discourse. So if, in a sense, the intellectuals have finally caught up to ordinary people, still there's all the difference in the world between the intellectuals who understand these things with a kind of ironic distance and a more naive religious faith. I am fascinated by Derrida's recovery of the *Confessions* of Saint Augustine, but Derrida talks about Saint Augustine with a distance; he hardly identifies with Augustine. Nor do I. While I love the *Confessions*, there's not a lot in the *City of God* that I accept. *The City of God* represents a good deal of what is wrong with Western Christianity—for instance, the attitude toward sexuality and the body, the dichotomy of time and eternity, the distinction between this world and the next world. But there is no ironic distance in the religious faith of the fundamentalists. Their faith is direct, nonironic, and reactionary. And my own take on that is twofold. 1. They know something that the intellectuals have forgotten; they affirm something that we must understand. 2. At the same time, their faith is reactionary; it has been stampeded into a literalist extreme by the deracinating effects of modern technology and global capitalism. Their beliefs and practices are dangerous and uncritical and hence this allows their religion to be manipulated for nationalistic purposes, held captive by the worst forces, forces that contradict everything that Jesus and the prophets stand for.

Granted that, though, is it fair to say that, even if it's a perverse or dangerous form of it, is it a kind of form of the affirmation and desire you had talked about earlier?

Yes, certainly. That is its ambiguity; that is the aporia. I do not claim millions of devout practicing Christians or Muslims have not seized upon something authentic. It's religion! It's re-

ligion good and bad, for better and worse, and it is not all bad. That's why in *On Religion* I did that analysis of one of my favorite movies in this regard, Robert Duval's *The Apostle*, which I think is a marvelous account of the tossing and turning about of a genuine religious passion in an evangelical congregation. One of the more striking features of that film was the way it treated race. The Apostle E.F.'s congregation was largely black, and his evangelical passion erased that racial divide and made them all brothers and sisters. It was genuine, it was real religious passion. E.F. was also conflicted in the Pauline sense, "Doing the things I will not and willing the things I do not."

Of course, it was a little bit of an artifact because it prescinded from larger political questions, which never got into that film. It was just a portrait of an individual soul, like the *Confessions*. And it was a powerful, beautiful portrait of biblical passion. One image that really struck me from that movie was the scene in which E.F. lays the Book down in front of the racist figure played by Billy Bob Thornton, which just stops that big John Deere machine in its tracks. As a Catholic viewer, I don't quite have that thing about a book, The Book. It's very powerful scene, and who am I to say that what's being portrayed there is not real, not authentic, and not profound? It is. But when reading becomes literalism and when literalism becomes a politics, it becomes dangerous. When we cease to understand the contingency of our traditions vis-à-vis competing traditions, they become dangerous. Now the thing is, one could ask, and I always ask myself this—is it possible to inhabit a construction, understanding that it's a construction? Can you inhabit a tradition with ironic distance?

You can, I think. I think Derrida must have done something like that, right?

Something like that, although he says he rightly passes for an atheist, so his inhabiting was even more ironic than the believer's.

But I think that his formula “rightly passing for” is a good one for everybody, including believers. It builds the distance and the irony into the belief, which is what I treasure in it.

On the other hand, I don't think someone like Martin Luther King Jr. understood his Christianity as contingent.

King's affirmation of justice was unconditional. But we would have had to ask him whether the Christian and biblical formulations he gave to this affirmation were equally unconditional. I also wonder if Bonhoeffer's idea of a religionless Christianity may not have implied this sense of contingency. But that is something that you may know more about than I.

Perhaps. He certainly saw a certain phase of Christianity coming to an end, but that was also its recovery and rehabilitation, to use the word you used before. It seems that so long as you live with the contingency and the irony at the front of your consciousness—it seems to me that the possibilities of genuine political applicability are weakened.

Well, then, maybe instead of being held in the front of your consciousness, they need to be in the back of your mind. Maybe the name or the construction is in the front of our mind but the event is in the back. In any case, we need to distinguish the construction and the event. The name is the historically inherited form of life, what is handed down to us by the tradition. Then there is what is astir within this name, its inner energy or life, what I am calling the *event* within it. But my only means of access to it is in the construction that I've inherited. To that extent, that construction is very precious and needs to be preserved. Without the institutions of the West, we would not have preserved the memory of Jesus. That's why I said to you before that I wouldn't want to go the way of individualism versus community, because communities preserve traditions and they pass on memories. One way to put it is to say that I am trying to

conceive of an absolute passion about something that's relative, that is, historically constituted. Kierkegaard tried to sort out an absolute passion for the absolute from a relative passion for the relative. In my Danish version of deconstruction I would rather speak of the affirmation of something unconditional, the event, that is always presenting itself under one condition or another, the construction.

By the unconditional I do not mean some supersensible being *up above*—that's what I share with death of God theology—but the event that stirs *within* the relative and contingent things around us. So I imagine a more porous situation in which we expend an absolute passion on what we know is relative or, more precisely, in which we affirm unconditionally the event that is always being given some relative conditioned expression. You always have to do with what you've inherited, your tradition and language. I know I'm white and male and a Christian and I know the situation in which I find myself, which provides me with my resources and my limits. I concede that, if I were born somewhere else in some other time, I would believe different things. But there's something that is soliciting me, something that is promised to me, something that provokes me, in what my traditions have handed down, about which I feel an unconditional response, to which I'm unconditionally committed. But the unconditional commitment is to something that is going on *in* the tradition, something that is happening, which I am calling the event, in the conditional structure. As Deleuze says, the event is not what happens but what is going on *in* what happens.

This idea of an absolute passion for the relative, it seems to me that's the definition of deconstruction. That deconstruction isn't something that happens from the zap of a deconstruction gun. Instead, you enter into something fully and, in doing that, you take it beyond its own limits or expose it to its own limitations.

Exactly. And it—this particular, inherited form of life—bursts under the strain of the unconditional event and is forced to reinvent itself anew. That is deconstruction in a nutshell. I'll have to add another chapter. [*Laughter*]

All right, to conclude with a wildly speculative question, in order to let you dream for a little bit: What do you believe the future holds for religion in general and Christianity in particular?

While I am eager to speak about the “to come” and the “promise,” I am loathe to make predictions. The true future for me is the unforeseeable. The predictions of the death of God back in the sixties, like the positivist predictions of the nineteenth century that religion was coming to an end or the Marxist and Freudian critiques of the future of an illusion—all of those things have taught us to stop saying “God is dead” when that means “religion is over.” Religious discourse, for the moment, seems to be an irreducible resource in our world. I don't see that either intellectuals or people of action will be able to do without it for the foreseeable future. It may be that it will dissipate. It may be that technology will so totally transform our existence in a hundred years or a thousand years that such things will be unrecognizable. And this kind of discourse will have evaporated. That could happen, but I must confess that I don't see that happening. Of course, that's exactly what one means by the absolute future: precisely what you don't see happening. So it could happen! I cannot imagine a future without religious discourse *and*, at the same time, that is what the absolute future means. Take the example of my own tradition. The Vatican is reassured that, despite the downward trend in vocations in Western Europe and the United States, vocations are flourishing in Africa and in Latin America. In the Western democracies it is in trouble, but, worldwide, Catholicism is doing fine. So, if your question means, do I think religion and Christianity have a future, then I

The Death of God

An Afterword

GABRIEL VAHANIAN

I A Maker of Words

As both a figure of speech and a method of interpretation, the death of God and deconstruction each equally burdens and unburdens itself upon the other. Like two hands, they extend the body, and it is no longer the same again. Like the two lips of a mouth, they open the body to the call of language, embodying that word by which they are embodied. World without end. Word without end. And they are also like the two extreme panels of a triptych folded over its central one, covering and uncovering it. Or, again, they are like a TV screen—and, come to think of it, doesn't a triptych "act" like a screen, which it somehow anticipates, though in a manner similar to a car moving forward while its wheels turn backwards? But then, what do either the death of God or deconstruction *actually* show?

Language *shows*, and what it shows is only what folds in it, hides in it: words held on a leash and yet capable of unleashing language itself. Language is not this or that, but only happens or *works*. It works when, caught up in the web of words, it *de-monstrates* what precisely it seems to demonstrate. It lies in the use

of words, not in their magic. It points to the moon, or to God, and, like a fool, you're looking at the finger as though the moon were expelled from the horizon of language. Both construing and deconstructing itself, language has no beginning in and of itself and no end, either. It is as recusant of the idol as it is propitious to God, so far as God and idol can be kept apart, or at least so far as God is not caught in a name as in a lasso. A name as such is no event: that's why God has no name and, if not by antiphrasis, is not seldom referred to by way of a periphrasis—such as kingdom of God or ultimacy (Caputo) or church and intimacy (Vattimo). Only as a matter of words is God an event of language. So is silence, let alone its would-be deconstructive final vocabulary, the death of God. As Augustine says, we speak not in order to say something, but in order not to say nothing.

Deconstruction cannot be critical of Egypt and of Canaan without being critical of Israel; it cannot be critical of the religious metaphysics of presence without being critical of the death of its God. As Rorty would say, after the death of God we have no God's eye view of things any more than we seemed to previously—or think we do “after Christianity.” Or, as Vattimo reminds us, the end of metaphysics has liquidated the philosophical basis for atheism. Call it deconstruction or by any other name, it must begin with itself, with an analysis of its own backyard, with a critique of its own background analysis.¹ Deconstruction cannot subvert God unless it also subverts itself together with the very idea of the death of God, a figure of speech after all more consonant with the presuppositions of a God taken for granted than with those of a world that can only take itself for granted and, serpentlike, bites its tail. Deconstruction is a matter of words—Derrida keeps reminding us—words that you don't find in nature or (if truth be told) in history. Only in language. In the light of which, your God being for me only an idol, mine, as soon as worshipped, by the same token, becomes one too.

correct, which ever since its inception has had no respite till it enshrined in the Sacred what remained of God, dead or otherwise.

Nietzsche says three things about the death of God: 1. We killed him; 2. Things used to be that way, now they are this way; 3. All that is left after so many centuries of Christian theory is the Bible—and you can think of it as Beckett's Gogo and Didi do in *Waiting for Godot* when all that Gogo remembers of the Word of God are the maps of the Holy Land and the pale blue color of the Dead Sea he wished he were swimming in—not exactly an inkling of baptismal desire, but so what? How else could anyone deprived of language and reduced to the neotenic status of human beings not yet even biologically humanized, let alone existentially spoken for in and through language? Gogo can only remember the Dead Sea, as does Nietzsche, who remembers a dead book. A tomb. Or does he? Could this book possibly also stand for an empty tomb?

1. Vattimo and Caputo are right: there is something Christian and perhaps rather Jewish about the death of God (which affects the order of things), even as there is something Greek about dying and rising Gods (which is indifferent to the nature of things). Amalgamating these two types of God, on the one hand, Christianity further desacralizes Greek religion and thus accounts for a process which had already been initiated by Greek thought, as Augustine will retrospectively aver. On the other hand, Christianity further secularizes Jewish religion and thus remains within the orbit of the prophets' vision of a new world consonant with their condemnation of Israel's election as a national privilege rather than as a universal obligation. And yet the Jewish periphrastic God differs with idols that bear a name and would not qualify as idols were it not for that name. If idols are quasi gods, by contrast God is not God in name only or by sole refraction of a name, either, as seems to be the case with the many gods of the Greek mind that refract the oneness of God. Combining both

trends, Christianity is compelled to assert or confess that no sooner is God worshipped than this very God becomes an idol. There is “no other God,” whether before or, for that matter, after God, before or after time or history or nature. God is not above and beyond time but strikes us with its timing, its *kairos*. In other words, the timing of that which, lasting forever, can and does only last once for all. Call it kingdom of God, which is all the more singular for being universal and all the more universal for being singular. Or call it word become flesh, a wording of God in and through the most local of all human-all-too-human idioms, through which being human is the task of a human being called to, spoken for, being neither the first nor the last, neither first Greek nor last Jew, and much less “man par excellence,” but man *tout court*—eventuating in that language which, turning dogma into poetry, turns lips into words. Into event.

We don’t always hear it (we don’t always hear a tree falling in the middle of the forest either). But that’s no reason to applaud with only one hand, only with half a brain, or altogether refrain from applauding with both hands, body and soul, flesh and spirit. With Caputo, I rejoice in his four-wheel-driven grammatological cavalcade riding in and out, processionlike, a theology of the event. For one thing, it does chase the taste of medical syrup that clings to his title, rather contrived. Like a trick which, by substituting depth of being for highest being, weakness for power, consists in dressing the wound differently, still in desperate need of healing. The so-called grace of God, pure and simple, is a matter neither of power nor of weakness; it is indifferent to both. It relies on its resilience to power and to weakness as well. And much less is its efficacy, confounding both, to be reduced to either. Caputo likes to quote Luther’s *Hier stehe ich*, which, far from a stubborn matter of fact, does not even echo a matter of conviction so much as a conviction that matters regardless of either power or weakness and thus seals a matter of conscience—better still, of the unconscious suddenly

coming into its own, eventuating in a language so far unheard-of, yet marking loud and clear a new dawning of the world to language, a new advent both to and of language, all previous hierarchic, authoritarian, premises to the contrary notwithstanding. We come into language as we come into the world—bare. And we come to God, or not, as we come to language. No language? No God. In the world's advent to language or of the unconscious to conscience, language, like the tower of Babel, is laid bare, so speechless it can only burst forth, at once recusant of the idol and propitious to God so far as God is no God, so far as no God is God, and God is beyond power and weakness, laying in a word as empty as a tomb on an Easter morning.

The word order that thus commands the Christian understanding of the world and its moral as well as social structure is no more theocratic than it is anarchic. Or it is both; depending on what is meant by each term, both imply that if power corrupts, as Lord Acton said, absolute power corrupts absolutely. In this respect, nothing is more anarchic than theocracy for which God is no *archè* and priesthood—or *sola scriptura* and its interpretation (pace Vattimo)—is no monopoly but an obligation that befalls all believers, especially if none pretends to being worthy of lording it over everybody else, aside from God. No God, no master—aside from a hardboiled unrepentant anarchist, even a theocrat could subscribe to this motto. No God? No master. Troeltsch hits the nail on the head when he suggests that Calvinistic theocracy is in fact a “Bibliocracy.” It rests on the primacy of Scripture—not of *scripta* so much as of *scriptura*, not of that which is written but of that which is “a-writing.” That is, it rests on the contingency of God's primacy or God's authority so long as God is a-wording in and through the worlding of the word become flesh. A process as symbolic as it is literal.

Nietzsche was right: it was time to bring an end to the positivism of ontotheism—that is, it was time for the death of God.

or the idol—not to the past metaphysics and its forgetfulness of Being so much as to the present and its forgetfulness of the Word. It applies not only to God but also to the world. Secularization, as we shall see, is the misbegotten Achilles' heel of Western thought in general. It is, more significantly, the unwanted offspring of meretricious theological theorizing turned sour.

Honestly put, it is because we pried the religious and the secular loose from each other and—Hegel notwithstanding, who blames it on the various guardians of the temple and, at that, was far from wrong—it is because we kept them apart that we killed God. A discrepancy between God and the world and an increasingly gaping hiatus between them: isn't that what Nietzsche is excoriating, given on the one hand what tools of grammar, what hoping against hope he can salvage from the wreckage of Christian Western rhetoric and, on the other hand, given the sudden outburst of a secret no Christian theorizing can withhold any longer and hide from the sight and hearing of the public square: "God is dead!" But is that a dead end? Unbeknownst to its specialists and other pallbearers, hasn't indeed the Bible, miraculously fallen in the public domain, taken away from its official interpreters and entrusted to whomever, having eyes to read, can read and in whose eyes, Scripture unfolding itself into new scripture, it interprets itself, deconstructing a future to which it would otherwise be fated as well as a past by which it would inevitably be obsessed? Luther: at once sinful and justified, a believer is likewise the perfectly free lord of all, subject to none, and the most dutiful servant, subject to all. Subversive? No less than the Bible, which defying—as well as standing up to—itsself, from one challenge to "it is written" runs to another and still another challenge.

To wit: Neither Judaism nor Christianity is a religion of the Book (or merely a religion of salvation in expectation of a fenced-in paradise). Of the Word, yes. Of God's being this or

that, no. God speaks, and the thing happens—the world is beautiful and outside of it there is no salvation (Camus), and Adam and Eve are spoken for one another. Immanent or transcendent, the world hangs on a word, literally and figuratively, not on an abstract God but, instead, on wording God through no other words than of this world's koine, through which alone is "God spoken here."

God is no God without the world, but the world is not God. God is love, but love is not divine either: it's too good a thing to be mostly enjoyed by characters, however divine, acting by proxy. And because God is word, one and the same thing amounts to saying either that love is God or that God is love spread throughout the worlding of the word. But, either way, throughout the Bible you're kept wondering what it's all about. Doesn't God seem more concerned about the Garden of Eden than about the world of which this garden is supposed to be emblematic? And, indeed, it does seem that God is more concerned about the former, but only because God is, so to speak, concerned not with a haphazard order of things but with their real word order, symbolic as well as literal. Take Cain: by murdering his brother Abel he screens off this word order from the order of the world, of the Sacred; he deafens the world to the primacy of the word, of the Holy. Why does God prefer one offering over another? Because even, and above all, love is a matter of words (far beyond even the slogan "Make love, not war!" Unless you make love with words, the neotenic sacred beast is still slumbering in you.)

3. God is a matter of words. So also is deconstruction a matter of language. Concepts come and go. Language hangs on its ability to transfer one tongue into another, transfer what's not transferable, namely, its secret, what holds it together as well as what is held together. Granted, the death of God is the secret of ontotheism. What task then befalls deconstruction has to do with

its contamination by a quest for some totalitarian universalism summed up in theodicy, which, however entertaining, is but a lateral excursion on the ontotheistic trip, a trip forgetful of the word even more than of Being—or of the corruption of power in the hands of power and its confusion with authority. Power is one thing, authority is another. Of power, you're on one side or the other. It divides. Authority is all encompassing: it rests on dissent as much as on consent. Delegated to so-called authorities, it is then no less but no more than delegated power and merely administrative, limited, as stipulated by John Cotton. Like anyone of that American period, with feet on the ground, Cotton knew that it is natural for administrations to perpetuate themselves. Above and beyond all else, they were accountable to the word (of God), not even to the powers that be. Not to sacralize power but to power secularized in view of hallowing the name of God, the word event of which this world is the worlding. The Holy Commonwealth consists neither in sacralizing its own decrees nor the religion on which it is weaned, let alone God, whose holiness it does not confuse with the Sacred—today elevated to the rank of the hermeneutic principle of the death of God.

No wonder, in spite of Gramsci's definition of religion as the most gigantic utopia ever to appear in history, as though orphaned by the death of God, religion is today identified with the Sacred. Worse still, it is merely an administration of it. I confess my surprise at the extent to which, in otherwise magnificent contributions to this book, both Caputo and Vattimo have been enticed by and have succumbed to the siren calls of the Sacred, an ersatz of God, an illusion of religion, a sociologists' dream of talking about God without talking about God or of the world's radical immanence by pulling the rug from under it. The profane, says Eliade, is that which is not sacred and, conversely, the Sacred is that which is not profane. It attaches to things or, for that matter, to beings. The Holy qualifies relations of the human to the divine,

of this to that, and subverts all objectification of sacralized entities and what they stand for (as in the parable of the Good Samaritan). The Western dialectic of God and the world has developed on the pattern of the religious (the holy) and the secular and its subversion of the dichotomy of the sacred and the profane.

Worth repeating here, equally if not more cumbersome is in my view the telescoping of the sacred with anarchy. Caputo's "hieranarchy" has the unenviable virtue of combining a tongue twister with a conundrum. What is aimed at is a further deconstruction of teleology in view of what he calls an ateleolgy, an end without an ending, not unlike anarchy, which, at the other end of the spectrum, is the rebuttal of archy. So far so good. But is, for all that, the progressivism or the ideal of perfectibility conveyed by teleology nipped in the bud? Is not hieranarchy itself throughout pervaded with the call of perfection, however achieved? Replace teleology with progress and you have anarchy, sacred or otherwise, sharing the ideal of perfection hovering over so-called theocracy.

True, Caputo himself has a hard time swallowing such hieranarchy. This does not exonerate Vattimo of his own penchant—a weak spot—for the sacred that still lurks in his globally more positive assessment of the secular. But he too, if not more than Caputo, should remember that nothing is more hierarchically organized than the rigid dichotomy of the sacral universe of discourse against which he grows quite eloquent in other respects: he debunks an all-male priesthood and yet seems reluctant to accept the idea of the priesthood of all believers (and its implicit anarchy).

III Worlding the Word

Let me conclude by rehearsing the following three propositions:
1. Beyond being and becoming, God as event of language; 2. The

secular as worlding of the word; 3. Not because but in spite of its Christian coloration, the secular is what (a fortiori the Christian) religion and the religions have in common.

1. We are in dire need of further cleaning up our stables, especially if “after Christianity” we must not go back to business as usual. *Post mortem dei*, the event Caputo rightly keeps by turn evoking and invoking, hangs for its happening on being carried out not as a mere figure of speech but through a reconfiguration of language, even its transfiguration. Being born to the world as a human being is no event. Being human is, and that leaves no trace other than language, which is the reason that, as Augustine says, we’re not human beings by nature but by grace. Being human depends on the human being’s advent to language. An event is a language event in the occurrence of which, as with an academic cursus, the fulfillment is the commencement and, likewise, ultimacy coincides with intimacy. Or transcendence with immanence, such that, however, transcendence hangs on radical immanence (the world is not God) and, reciprocally, immanence on radical transcendence (God is God, though not without the world). Built is thus a dialectic the biblical tradition calls hallowing, whose two prongs (sorry if I keep flirting with one anachronism after another) are the religious and the secular, not the sacred and the profane. Why? Because rather than religion being the administration of the sacred, the religious consists in overcoming the religious and reciprocally the secular in overcoming the secular, as Amos and the prophets and Jesus remind us. Hallowing the Name or worlding the word is no sacralizing of any kind, but is even more consonant with secularizing not only religion but also the world itself so far as, on the one hand, the world is always the world of a religion, whether exclusive (theocracy) or pluralistic (anarchy) and, on the other hand, what these two options have in common is the logocratic hinge of

spite warnings about this secularity of its faith and the positive balance of the process of secularization, it allows for the secular to be snatched away. Despite the fact that it had long since turned away from the world, understood as being only worthy of contempt, to its radical affirmation, secularism (at the expense of secularity) will become the sole beneficiary of this process, further abetted by modernist scientism. Like blind fideism, secularism is not spared of dogmatism either. Only with the aftermath of modernity will the secular begin to recover its erstwhile plasticity in the couple it formed with the religious. Derrida himself is eloquently sensitive to this.

Of course, though twin to the religious, historically it first appears with the accoutrements of worldliness. But, soon transfigured, it will instantiate the worldhood of the world (as already suggested by Augustine), whether by concretizing the religious or acting, so to speak, as its unconscious. In this dyad of the religious and the secular, both result from, and are vindicated by, the notion of a God who speaks, and whose word lies in worlding the word as well as in becoming flesh. Incarnation, no invention of the New Testament, has the same eschatological roots as creation. Salvation is not the only aspect of incarnation. Jesus comes proclaiming the kingdom: equally, if not more, important is this other eschatological dimension. "Worlding the word" tries to gather both aspects.

No, you cannot isolate a text from its context, its margins (a book page heavily depends on its margins). Mainline theologians should lend an ear to marginal ones, though they are often classified as heretics. The first and arch-heretic of them all was Marcion. Comparing both testaments, he says history (read the secular) is (at best) what both testaments have in common. In the light of an inchoate Christian movement, Tertullian identified the secular with polytheistic paganism. But we are no less

mistaken today when we cut off the secular from the religious and let an atheistic posture of secularism unilaterally preempt the world of its genuine worldhood. Nevertheless, since Augustine the world is what, in the light of the dialectic of hallowing, Christianity has in common with the world religions. Caputo knows this. Vattimo too. Don't they tone it down? They grow eloquent in calling for overcoming religion through religions. What about the like effort at overcoming the secular through the secular? Why not? Metaphysics is what Christianity inherited from Greek antiquity and invested in its acculturation of faith and, yes, in the secularization thereof, even at the forbidding cost of the death of God. But will the scales ever fall off everyone's eyes? The secular is what Christianity has bequeathed to a world in a process of globalization, and, just for this reason, rather than being exhausted by the death of God, it faces a new challenge.

Notes

Introduction

1. See Gabriel Vahanian, *The Death of God: The Culture of Our Post-Christian Era* (New York: Braziller, 1961).

2. See Richard J. Rubenstein, *After Auschwitz: Essays in Contemporary Judaism* (New York: Macmillan, 1966).

3. See John Robinson, *Honest to God* (Philadelphia: Westminster Knox, 1972), and Harvey Cox, *The Secular City: Secularization and Urbanization in Theological Perspective* (New York: Macmillan, 1966).

4. See Thomas J. J. Altizer, *The Gospel of Christian Atheism* (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1966).

5. Sociologist of religion Richard Fenn describes this ideological crisis as follows: "The emergence of the radical death of God theology, therefore, is set within a cultural context of ideological crisis: in the absence of universals, of world-views and value-orientations, of sanctions for social arrangements, and of prototypes for individual motivations, the new theology acquires an empirical fit and significance far broader than its sources in academic theology would suggest." In "The Death of God: An Analysis of Ideological Crisis," *Review of Religious Research* 9, no. 3 (Spring 1968): 171.

6. Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri, *Empire* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2000), p. 46.

7. Mark C. Taylor, *Erring: A Postmodern A/theology* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1984), p. 6. In making this claim, Taylor is echoing a claim first made by Carl Raschke in *Deconstruction and Theology* (1982).

8. As the historian Hugh McLeod writes, “‘Christianity’ and ‘Christendom’ can be separated. There was Christianity for three centuries before Christendom. There are parts of the world, for instance China, where there has never been a Christendom, but where there are many millions of Christians.” In Hugh McLeod, “Introduction,” in *The Decline of Christendom in Western Europe, 1750–2000*, ed. Hugh McLeod and Werner Ustorf (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2003), p. 2.

9. *Ibid.*, p. 1.

10. Elaine Pagels, *Beyond Belief: The Secret Gospel of Thomas* (New York: Random House, 2003), p. 168.

11. McCleod, “Introduction,” p. 1.

12. *Ibid.*, p. 2.

13. See Dietrich Bonhoeffer, *Letters and Papers from Prison*, ed. Eberhard Bethge (New York: Macmillan, 1972).

14. See especially William Hamilton, “Dietrich Bonhoeffer” in *Radical Theology and the Death of God*, ed. Thomas J.J. Altizer and William Hamilton (New York: Bobbs-Merrill, 1966), pp. 113–20.

15. Søren Kierkegaard, *Attack Upon Christendom* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1972).

16. Jack Miles, “Religion is Making a Comeback (Belief to Follow),” *New York Times Magazine* (December 7, 1997).

17. See Immanuel Kant, “What Is Enlightenment?” in *The Portable Enlightenment Reader*, ed. Isaac Kramnick (New York: Penguin, 1995).

18. See John D. Caputo, *Radical Hermeneutics: Repetition, Deconstruction, and the Hermeneutic Project* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1987), and *More Radical Hermeneutics: On Not Knowing Who We Are* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2000).

19. Richard Rorty, “Foreword,” in Gianni Vattimo, *Nilism and Emancipation*, ed. Santiago Zabala (New York: Columbia University Press, 2004), p. xi.

20. Vattimo, *Nilism and Emancipation*, p. xxvi.

21. *Ibid.*, p. 19.

22. *Ibid.*, xxvi.

23. Caputo has acknowledged his indebtedness to Vattimo on this point. See the introduction to his forthcoming *The Weakness of God: A Theology of the Event* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2006), n. 9.

24. See John D. Caputo, *The Prayers and Tears of Jacques Derrida: Religion Without Religion* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1997).

25. For more about Caputo's theology of the event, see *The Weakness of God*.

26. Gianni Vattimo, *After Christianity*, trans. Luca D'Isanto (New York: Columbia University Press, 2002), p. 17.

27. See Gianni Vattimo, *Belief*, trans. Luca D'Isanto and David Webb (New York: Columbia University Press, 1999), p. 28.

28. John D. Caputo, *Demythologizing Heidegger* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1993), pp. 7–8.

29. See John D. Caputo, *Against Ethics: Contributions to a Poetics of Obligation with Constant Reference to Deconstruction* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1993).

30. John D. Caputo, *On Religion* (New York: Routledge, 2001), pp. 37–66. Further references will appear parenthetically in text.

31. See Vattimo, *After Christianity*, pp. 69–82.

32. Gianni Vattimo, *The Transparent Society*, trans. David Webb (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1992), p. 1. Further references will appear in text.

33. See Vattimo, *Belief*, pp. 80–84.

Toward a Nonreligious Christianity

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1. Erich Auerbach, *Mimesis: The Representation of Reality in Western Literature*, trans. Willard R. Trask (Princeton University Press, 2003).

2. Richard Rorty has explained very well this issue by showing that it is the linguistic turn that has led us away not only from epistemology but also from traditional metaphysics because we never understand anything except under a description, and there are no privileged descriptions. We should interpret the phrase *understanding an object* as a slightly misleading way of

describing our ability to connect old descriptions with new. "Being That Can Be Understood Is Language," in *Gadamer's Repercussions: Reconsidering Philosophical Hermeneutics*, ed. Bruce Krajewski (University of California Press: 2004), 21–29.

3. I have analyzed this problem in my *After Christianity*, trans. Luca D'Isanto (New York: Columbia University Press, 2002).

4. There are some very interesting books on the origin of interpretation available now as Kathy Eden, *Hermeneutics and the Rhetorical Tradition* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1997); Gerald L. Bruns, *Hermeneutics: Ancient and Modern* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1992); Gayle L. Ormiston, and Alan D. Schrift, eds., *Transforming the Hermeneutic Context: From Nietzsche to Nancy* (New York: State University of New York Press, 1990), and *The Hermeneutic Tradition: From Ast to Ricoeur* (New York: State University of New York Press, 1990).

5. Martin Heidegger, *The Phenomenology of Religious Life*, trans. Matthias Fritsch and Jennifer Anna Gosetti (Indiana University Press, 2004).

6. Benedetto Croce, "Why We Cannot Help Calling Ourselves Christians" (1942) in *My Philosophy*, trans. E.F. Carritt (New York: Collier, 1962).

7. Charles Baudelaire, *The Painter of Modern Life and Other Essays*, trans. Jonathan Mayne (London: Phaidon, 1964).

8. Editor's note: By charity, the author does not mean simply the act of almsgiving or of helping the poor. The actual word he uses is that of *caritas*, which has a broader meaning than that of charity alone. It refers to grace and love or the generosity of spirit and the act of self-giving upon which genuine charity is properly founded.

9. Giovanni Pascoli (1855–1912) was an Italian poet and classical scholar. He was the longtime chair of literature at the University of Bologna. He is best remembered for his experimental poetry, which incorporated his extensive knowledge of classical antiquity. He wrote in both Italian and Latin and also translated English poetry.

Spectral Hermeneutics

1. While points 4 and 5 are obviously of Derridean inspiration, the background for points 1–3 is found in Gilles Deleuze, *The Logic of Sense*, ed. Constantin V. Boundas, trans. Mark Lester with Charles Stivale (New

5. Deleuze is closest to Derrida, and I am closest to Deleuze, when Deleuze insists that the event is not what occurs but “something *in* that which occurs, something yet to come,” which “signals” us and “waits for us and invite us in.” *The Logic of Sense*, p. 148.

6. When Deleuze speaks of willing the event as willing what happens to us, which sounds like countersigning everything that happens as inevitable, he is trying to rehabilitate Nietzsche’s doctrine of eternal recurrence. He would have done a lot better to follow Badiou’s advice and drop the whole idea of *amor fati*, because it is only getting in the way of what he really means by willing the event. Deleuze avoids the fatalist implication only by saying that we should love not *whatever* happens, but rather the event that transpires *in* what happens, a distinction that completely transforms the Nietzschean theory to the point of near unrecognizability. See *The Logic of Sense*, p. 149,

7. “Nothing more can be said, and no more has ever been said: to become worthy of what happens to us, and thus to will and release the event, to become the offspring of one’s own events, and thereby to be reborn, to have one more birth, and break with one’s carnal birth—to become the offspring of one’s events and not of one’s actions, for the action is itself produced by the offspring of the event” (*The Logic of Sense*, pp. 149–50). Deleuze, in short, every bit as much as any evangelical Christian, wants to be “born again.” And who does not? Who would not want a chance to make another start, to have one more birth, and this time around to glow with all “the splendor and magnificence of the event,” with a divine splendor, having taken on a divine glow!

8. In *The Logic of Sense* the event is artfully cast as an irreducible irreality, in a certain dialogue with Husserl (pp. 96–99), or as an “absolute nature,” in a surprising dialogue with Avicenna (p. 34). Either way, the event cannot be reduced to any of its mundane appearances and is allowed to circulate freely in a joyous indifference both to the existential sphere, where it is realized under the conditions of individuality, and to the logical sphere, where it is expressed under the conditions of universality.

9. That is the force of Derrida’s distinction between the pure messianic that haunts the historical messianisms like a ghost. The same cause is promoted by Badiou’s work of showing the Pauline proportions of the event, where “God is not partial” and the event is not restricted to a particular group specifically set apart by a privileged ethnicity, social status, or gender.

naturalism; but I also displace the notion of God as the Being of beings, or ground of Being as ontologism, and I locate the properly deconstructive or postmodern element of radical theology in God, or rather the event that transpires in the name of God, taken as the claim made upon us unconditionally but without force, physical or metaphysical, ontical or ontological. That might be called a “death of God” theology but, for the reasons I give below, I take that to be a misleading description.

14. Badiou, *Ethics*, 47.

15. In a kind of postmodern analogy to Tillich’s point that religion has to do with an ultimate concern, let us say here that it has to do with an irreducible or even unconditional desire, as opposed to our more proximate and quotidian desires. We cannot produce a final formulation of our desire, but that is not bad news, for it gives rise to an incessant and productive stream of provisional formulations of what we desire, which is what Tillich meant by symbolic. These formulations are cut to fit the needs of what Heidegger called the factual situation in which we find ourselves, which is why these formulations are “hermeneutical,” albeit with a hermeneutics that requires radicalization. Deleuze himself touched upon one of the most famous of such formulations of our desire—the desire for a new birth—when he spoke of “becom[ing] the offspring of one’s own events, and thereby to be reborn, to have one more birth, and to break with one’s carnal birth” (*The Logic of Sense*, pp. 149–50). Whether he appreciates it or not, Deleuze here drifts appreciably close to Paul’s theology of grace: we have put off the body of death, guilt, and transgression and made the transition to a new life, from the flesh to the Spirit, from the old creation to a new creation, from the old being to the new being, or, with a slightly postmodern twist, from the economy to the crowned anarchy of the gift, of grace.

16. To be sure, inasmuch as the “New Testament” is a vintage example of a “text,” a pastiche woven from multiple authors and redactors with multiple theologies in different churches transcribed by not always neutral scribes, I am prepared to concede that this thesis is frequently enough contradicted by the opposing thesis, by a good deal of bravado about the mighty power of God.

17. It is also worth noting that the entire passage begins with a citation of Isaiah 29:14, in which the prophet has God say: “I will destroy the wisdom of the wise.” If we recall that “destroy” (*apolo*) was rendered into Latin in the

vulgate by *destruere*, which was picked up by Luther in the Heidelberg disputations, who spoke of a *destructio* of pagan philosophy (Aristotle's metaphysics), which was then passed on to Heidegger, who spoke of a *Destruktion* of the history of metaphysics, which was translated by Derrida as *déconstruction*, then we might offer the following translation of this passage from Isaiah: "I will deconstruct the metaphysics of presence of the philosophers, says the Lord God." By which the sacred authors certainly meant, on my view, I will release the event these philosophers mean to prevent. Let my events go!

18. On the orthodox telling, this death was the embodiment par excellence of divine love and divine freedom, an act of supremely free identification with the human condition, made in sacrificial payment for the sins of the world. Like a lot of other writers today, I am not edified by the spectacle of a bloody sacrifice made for any reason, by anybody to anybody, and I am even less edified by the bloody sacrifice of the Divine Son to the Divine Father. I find the very idea of blood sacrifice primitive and the idea of a father requiring or being satisfied by such a sacrifice of his son to be morally repugnant. Of course, on my terms, this entire discourse is symbolic, but symbols are important. One should avoid a symbolic description of the scene of Jesus's execution rooted in an excess of patriarchal violence and a violent masculine imaginary.

19. See Jacques Derrida, *Rogues: Two Essays on Reason*, trans. Pascale-Anne Brault and Michael Naas (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2005). Derrida distinguishes the law from justice by saying that bad laws have force but lack justice, while justice of itself has no force but lays claim to us unconditionally. On this Derridean schema, God is more like justice than the law. See Jacques Derrida, "The Force of Law: 'The Mystical Foundation of Authority,'" trans. Mary Quantaince, in Drucilla Cornell, Michel Rosenfeld, and David Gray Carlson, eds., *Deconstruction and the Possibility of Justice* (New York: Routledge, 1992), pp. 3–69.

20. Deleuze, *The Logic of Sense*, p. 148.

21. That is, of course, an almost irresistible way to imagine the event. Still, it is possible to cooperate with the irresistible forces of imagination without being deceived by them. That is what we call literature—the willing suspension of disbelief—or scripture, Sacred or not so sacred. But it is in the end a mystification to treat these figures and images literally—even a dangerous mystification—if the result is to get us in the habit of depending upon a bail out by this divine superbeing at critical moments when things

40. Vattimo, *Belief*, pp. 83–84.

41. *Ibid.*, p. 84.

42. See John D. Caputo, *Radical Hermeneutics* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1986), pp. 108–19 (especially 112–13).

A Prayer for Silence

1. See Gianni Vattimo, *After Christianity*, trans. Luca D’Isanto (New York: Columbia University Press, 2002), p. 17.

2. Gianni Vattimo, *Nihilism and Emancipation*, ed. Santiago Zabala, trans. William McCuaig (New York: Columbia University Press, 2004).

The Power of the Powerless

1. See Gregg Lambert, “Against Religion (Without ‘Religion’): A New Rationalist Reply to John Caputo’s *On Religion*,” *Journal for Cultural and Religious Theory* 5, no. 2 (April 2004): 20–36. See also Caputo’s response to Lambert, “Love Among the Deconstructibles: A Response to Gregg Lambert,” *Journal for Cultural and Religious Theory* 5, no. 2 (April 2004): 37–57.

2. See Charles Winquist, “Postmodern Secular Theology,” in *The Surface of the Deep* (Aurora, CO: Davies, 2003), pp. 199–212.

The Death of God

1. Which reminds me: the subtitle of my first book, *The Death of God*, was deliberately truncated by my editor, a noted literary critic, and changed from “a cultural analysis” to “the culture of our post-Christian era.” Only later did I learn from a reputed French philosopher that *analysis*, the word expunged, is precisely the term by which ancient Greeks would have rendered what we were beginning to call deconstruction.

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